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Virginia Board of Education, Business Meeting, Thursday, April 22, 2021

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- Official meeting video (VDOE, YouTube): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=lexBvJdBJHo
- Board of Education meetings, agendas and minutes (VDOE): https://www.doe.virginia.gov/state-board-data-funding/virginia-board-of-education

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[00:00:15] Morning. Morning. Just to let everybody know, we are live on YouTube. I'm going to go ahead and share my screen briefly just to have the title slide up and then we'll get started here

[00:00:42] in just a minute. Good morning. So we have all of us online right now, right? Yes, hold on. I'm just

[00:01:38] doing my count real quick. Sorry, I'm having unstable connection problems. Yes, we have everyone that we're just missing Dr. Robertson but he's not able to join us today so we do have everyone that is supposed to be here here okay let me know

[00:02:09] when we are we are live so I think President Gecker we can go ahead and get started 10 o'clock welcome to everybody and welcome back to the board members for I guess day three uh yet another meeting of the hardest working most underpaid board in the commonwealth the virginia board of education uh we'll do a roll call first in the quick announcements uh dr wilson here miss davis vaut i know i heard her before she's muted but she's

[00:02:47] speaking present sir thank you dr duran present uh miss holton here uh dr man here dr pexton here and mr swan here and dr robertson has noted is absent uh good morning welcome to the board of education's virtual meeting our meeting today is being streamed live on the vboe youtube channel and on

the board's public meeting web page we'd like to welcome those joining us on the live screen from across the commonwealth a couple of things to note about our virtual meeting

[00:03:25] uh the board accepted written public comment for this meeting all comments that were received by 5 p.m. on Tuesday have been uploaded to our meeting web page and shared with board members in time for them to review in advance of today's meeting. Comments received after 5 p.m. on Tuesday will be provided to the board in a timely manner. For our YouTube watchers, the chat feature is disabled as it is not monitored by staff. The best way to contact the board is by email at boe as in board of education at doe.virginia.gov. I am pleased to announce that unless something

[00:04:01] changes today will be the last virtual meeting for the board we do plan to resume in-person meetings in june while still adhering to all the current social distancing and masking requirements more details about the location will be released as we get closer to the june 16 17 of 2021 meeting dates i will note that we do plan to continue to offer a live stream option as we have done for many years uh before we move into the agenda i would also like to make an edit to uh the agenda related to items g and h we have recently been made aware of some additional flexibility with regard to the

[00:04:37] timeline required for board action on the training and guidance requirements of house bill 1904 and senate bill 1196. given that additional flexibility we're going to defer items g and h until the june board meeting all right uh have board members had a chance to review the meeting minutes for the march 17 and 18 meetings uh are there edits or is there a motion to adopt as drafted i move to adopt both sets of minutes as drafted uh thank you dr wilson is there a second

[00:05:13] second uh thank you dr duran okay again by uh voice by roll call here dr wilson aye uh miss davis vaught aye dr duran aye ms holton aye dr mann aye uh dr pexton aye mr swan and i vote aye okay uh to the consent agenda is there are there any items anybody would like to remove from the consent agenda or alternatively is there a motion to adopt the consent agenda

[00:05:49] as drafted or as set forth motion to adopt thank you dr mann is there a second second sir thank you miss uh davis vaut all right again by roll call dr wilson aye miss davis vaut aye dr duran Sorry, aye. Ms. Holton. Aye. Dr. Mann. Aye. Dr. Pexton. Aye. And Mr. Swan. And I vote aye.

[00:06:27] Okay. That brings us to item D, final review of withdrawal of the proposed stage of the periodic review of the regulations governing educational services for gifted students. Mr. Boling, I think. Yeah. Mr. Boling. Yes. Hi. Good morning. Good morning, President Gecker, Dr. Lane members of the board this morning I bring to you item d responsive to the board's discussion at the march 18th 2021 board meeting for background on march 12 2021 the board received

[00:07:02] two letters from the african-american superintendent's advisory council one letter addressing advancing racial equity in virginia's public schools and another encouraging the board to issue guidance on the governance of academic year governor schools the impetus behind the letter requesting the board to issue guidance on the governance of academic year governor schools came from house bill 2305 delegate tyler from the 21 general assembly that bill required the board of education to issue guidance on the governance of academic year governor schools

[00:07:41] including communication on outreach practices admissions policies and guidelines on diversity Equity and Inclusion Training. This bill was passed indefinitely by the Senate's Education and Health Committee. Subsequently, the board engaged in a discussion at the March 18, 2021 business

meeting and suggested the desire to withdraw the previously approved regulations governing educational services for gifted students to allow time for additional review. Withdrawal of the regulations today would allow staff time for additional review of the proposed language and

[00:08:18] consideration of additions or edits responsive to the suggestions and recommendations and feedback received and additional feedback from the public the superintendent of public instruction recommends that the board approve the withdrawal of the proposed stage of the periodic review of the regulations governing educational services for gifted students okay thank you mr bowling is there uh anybody on the board who'd like to speak to this issue miss halton just one very brief brief question for Mr. Bowling. I confess that I have not gone back and looked at the proposed

[00:08:58] draft that was in process. I take it I know you all have and I take it. It does not adequately address the issues does not appear to adequately address the issues that we have recently been discussing with regard to gifted education. So in other words, there's a need to go back and look at it this right yes ma'am thank you there is a need yes okay and again to make it clear for the public this withdrawal is uh really not to stop these regs but again to look at revisions to the

[00:09:36] regs in light of certain comments that have you know come up since we put these regs out there anybody else if not is there a motion to uh you know withdraw those regs so moved president thank you dr wilson is there a second second thank you dr pexton all right roll call dr wilson

[00:10:05] aye miss davis vaught aye dr duran hi miss holton hi dr mann hi dr pexton hi mr swan and i vote aye okay item e final review of withdrawal of the proposed stage of the regulations establishing standards for accrediting public schools in virginia to comport with legislative changes from house bill 1215 that's from the 2012 general assembly dr sale thank you president gecker um and thank you president wilson members of the board and dr lane um it is my

[00:10:44] pleasure to be back in front of the board this morning um and also pleasure to be somewhat of an encore to mr bowling's presentation um since he really set the stage for both his item and my own um so like the one before it this item is going to ask the board to consider withdrawing a regulatory action currently in the proposed stage in order to allow additional time for staff and the board to review based on new information and context.

[00:11:11] So the regulatory action in front of us this morning pertains to the board's regulations establishing standards for accrediting public schools in Virginia, which we more commonly known as the standards of accreditation. And in 2012, the board had initiated action to amend the standards of accreditation to comport with new legislation passed in that 2012 session which had addressed or rather tasked the board of education to promulgate regulations specific to standards of accreditation of public virtual schools that enroll students full-time these standards were intended to address those situations in which a public school student would take all of their coursework virtually

[00:11:50] rather than in the traditional brick and mortar setting so this regulatory action did not proceed past the proposed stage so our last action to date was on july 2nd 2015. though it's unclear exactly what delayed further action on these regulations there remains a clear need and perhaps even arguably a heightened need to ensure virtual education regulations are updated and implemented so in withdrawing the proposed regulations staff would have the opportunity to revise and the board would have the opportunity to review and approve new virtual regulations that

[00:12:27] consider the growing interest in and potential for the use of virtual education, the service delivery model that is unique to the virtual setting, and of course the need to establish more consistent standards and expectations for the virtual education experience with the intent that we drive high quality instruction and student achievement in all settings across the board.

[00:12:47] And this is also an opportunity for us to build on lessons learned and best practices in the virtual education space that weren't available to us during the original action and of course we've seen a lot evolved in the last five five now six years so as mr bowling noted the board's authority to consider this action comes from the administrative processes act and allow for the withdrawal of regulation or of a regulatory action at any point in the process before those regulations become effective so with that i will hand it back to the board noting that the superintendent of public instruction does recommend the board approve the withdrawal of these proposed stage regulations

[00:13:23] okay thank you dr sale is there any questions about board members i mean actually as dr sale noted it's a mystery why we didn't finish out that we in this case being our predecessor board didn't finish the process that was mandated in 2012 by the general assembly however since that time uh you know we have completely revamped the standards of accreditation and so it's not clear frankly uh whether the 2012 action or what was requested could be done in the same form it's being done today that's number one and number two also as dr sale mentioned uh it may be time to

[00:14:00] look at a more uh robust uh you know or more robust regulations regarding virtual uh delivery of content you know it's clearly going to be here to stay and maybe we ought to think a little bit more about uh what we're doing in that regard we could not do that under the existing as the regs have been put out right now under the existing notices so we are likely going to have to do I would assume and Susan I know is on the call a new notice of intent of regulatory action in order to do all the things we ought to do in this case. Yes if you want to go beyond just what that

[00:14:38] bill did from 2012 you would need to issue a new Nora and specify the scope of the intended action. right so this will be a new significant piece of work for us actually uh in any event that's my summary of item e which i hope doesn't differ too much from dr sales to the extent they differ dr sale ought to be considered correct so uh miss holton just very briefly uh can we ask uh that uh ms williams council look before we make a final determination because that original nora might have been pretty broad i mean the man legislative man was pretty broad if the nora

[00:15:18] was pretty broad you know I just yes we need to do a lot of work here I'm sure but the breadth of well just recognizing that we're way beyond already anything we can do to accelerate the process while we do good careful work would be wonderful and the Nora APA question over my pay grade but just let's make sure we need to do it again before we do it yeah it's not going to cost us a lot of time and i think the will the intent is to issue the nora in june if that doesn't cost us a lot of time my concern is addressed yep and just so you'll know i have reviewed the nora and it is specific

[00:15:57] to um comporting with that legislation so it would be restrictive in that manner we have had significant discussion about this miss halton thank you thank you uh anybody else if not is there a motion so moved president gecker thank you dr wilson is there a second thank you thank you miss davis fought uh again roll call dr wilson president gecker yes president gecker before you move forward i just want to clarify that the motion is to withdraw not just the proposed stage

[00:16:33] but the proposed stage and the nora stage is that correct i think that's what i heard is the motion i just wanted to clarify dr wilson i assume that's what you meant yes it is absolutely yeah the board's on top of it emily but thank you thank you all right dr wilson aye uh miss davis vaught aye dr duran aye miss holton aye uh dr mann aye dr pexton aye mr swan aye and i vote aye

[00:17:13] uh thank you all very much for that okay item f uh first review the proposed approval of the region seven joint operated virtual school the region seven virtual academy uh mr bowling and i guess you'll introduce your presenters also i will thank you good morning again good to see you president gecker dr lane members of the board item f brings a formal request uh for consent to establish a joint operated school in Virginia as required by 22.126 of the Code of Virginia.

[00:17:46] Section 22.126 requires the Virginia Board of Education's consent when two or more school boards wish to establish a joint or regional school or program. 13 school divisions and Superintendents Region 7 have partnered together to create the Region 7 Virtual Academy.

[00:18:07] The Region 7 Virtual Academy is being established to alleviate the participating school division's demands of providing both remote and in-person learning opportunities. Details regarding the establishment of the Region 7 Virtual Academy are included in Attachment A, including an overview budget and course offering options by approved providers and Virtual Virginia.

[00:18:31] This item is being brought to the board today for first review. At this time, I'll turn it over to Dr. Keith Perigin, superintendent of Bristol Schools, who will provide additional information and answer any questions that you may have.

[00:18:48] - Thank you, Mr. Boling. Mr. Gecker, members of the board, Dr. Lane, appreciate the opportunity to present today. Mr. Gecker, you actually set this up perfectly for me in the last item when you mentioned that virtual learning is here to stay. And I think we realize that here in region seven and back in October, well, I guess to set the stage, In case members of the board do not know, many school divisions in Southwest Virginia have been providing in-person, fully in-person opportunities for students to learn since August.

[00:19:19] We've also provided the opportunity for students and families who want to remain remote to stay in that format as well. And this is not true across the entire region, but it's pretty close. We started out the school year with about 70% of our students learning fully in-person and about 30% of our students learning virtually.

[00:19:38] because our school divisions are small, we were unable to assign teachers just to the virtual world or the in-person world. And so we actually had teachers, all of our teachers teaching both in-person students and virtual students. As you can imagine, that is quite a task.

[00:19:54] And as we moved through the fall, it became more and more apparent that the coronavirus was not gonna end soon. And we realized that we would be providing virtual instruction into next year and probably for the remainder of our school careers because as Mr. Gecker said, Pandora's box has been open and virtual learning is here to stay.

[00:20:18] We knew that we could provide virtual learning, but we could not continue to ask our teachers to live in both worlds, and so a group of superintendents from Region 7 got together in October and started talking about how we could come together as a region and provide this to take that burden off of our teachers and off of our small school divisions. We realized very quickly that that was the way to move

forward. A couple days later, we met with Michael Boling, since he has experience in setting up a regional academy, not virtual, but a regional academy nonetheless, and decided that we were going to work with the Department

[00:20:57] of Ed about moving forward to do this. And the purpose being that we want to take, as mentioned earlier take the load off of our teachers we also have the added benefit of taking care of some of those hard to staff teaching areas because we're coming together and working together as an entire region we also realize that that would provide additional opportunities for our students to take courses from a regional standpoint that they might not be able to take if they stayed in just their division alone but also we were seeing some declines in enrollment because our students were enrolling with multi-divisional online providers

[00:21:34] and by creating a virtual academy we would protect ourselves from future loss of enrollment to mops because we would have that option available ourselves and so initially we had planned to create a curriculum in an online environment on our own with our own staff and hiring our own staff but very quickly that idea morphed and I will turn the mic over to Dr. Rob Graham from Radford and he can tell you what happened next in that process. Thank you Dr.

[00:22:02] Parage and then um President Gecker, members of the board, Dr. Lane and others certainly appreciate the uh opportunity to uh to be here with you this morning and uh listen on our behalf as we request for the Region 7 Virtual Academy and as Keith said this is this is something that's been really uh it's kind of been fun to to go through the process and and we're so close as a region and feel very comfortable with each other and feel really fortunate during these trying times to have each other here in Region 7 too. So as Keith said, I've been lucky enough to partner

[00:22:37] with Stride this year and in one of our meetings, you know, trying to wrap my head around trying to do this as on our own to provide remote learning to all our students in Region 7 just was was just too much if that kept me up at night sometimes too but uh reached out to to stride and said you know would you consider being a a provider for us and and then that kind of got the ball rolling um got in touch with with brian mott with virtual virginia he's been absolutely wonderful and and a partner now too and then edgenuity reached out to us uh all three of those

[00:23:14] folks we've had wonderful experience with in region seven and and just found them to be extremely supportive so we have three online platforms that allow region seven students who want to be remote next year the option of choosing and and has saved the region seven superintendents a whole lot of work i mean an enormous amount of work and then we were lucky enough to hire you can see caitlin's on here right now caitlin cosme who is going to be our executive director and thank goodness we have her she has just jumped on board and and um just taken the the

[00:23:51] bull by the horns and and and really uh expanded our our academy and and uh you know we're at the point now where we're finalizing our agreements with with uh the two entities that we have with stride and ingenuity uh we've worked with brian already and he's he's ready to go too um so she She has certainly been an asset for us, and I'm gonna just turn it over to her a little bit to let you know a little bit more about what we're doing and how we're gonna move forward too.

[00:24:20] So, Caitlin. Sure, thank you. Dr. Gecker, Mayor of the Board, Dr. Lane, we appreciate your time today. I will say, we now have 19 divisions in Region 7, and now we're actually up to 17 out of those 19 participating in the Regional Academy.

[00:24:36] The document that you have, I think, as an attachment in your notes there, kind of lays out our plan, but at this time we'll be happy to answer any questions that you may have. I know you maybe had a few on the first look, so we'll be happy to answer any questions that you may have at this time.

[00:24:58] Mr. Swan. How does this affect the federal funding for each school division? Is it a matter of just transferring those funds to the virtual academy, and will the school division lose funding for those particular students that are going to the virtual academy Mr. Swan first of all congratulations on the awesome award the well-deserved award that you've received this year and that is a great question students will remain enrolled in the sending divisions they will we will continue to provide many of the services that students have that are

[00:25:35] outside of the instructional model the virtual academy will only provide the instruction the sending school divisions will provide all other services and they will remain on uh the enrollment of the sending division follow-up please mr swan i'm sorry um the virtual academy will keep up with the attendance correct so what happens when there's a broadband issue um how will you guys address attendance will the student be still counted absent and it counts against their

[00:26:13] academics how will that be addressed the the one of the great things about coming together as a region to do this we also maintain autonomy as divisions and so in Bristol we have very good broadband access thankfully but many school divisions in region 7 do not and so there the local divisions will handle those attendance issues as they do in their normal attendance policy and the local divisions will also make decisions based upon how they provide broadband access to students who may not have it otherwise but those though even though we're coming together as a region to provide the service local divisions will still have a lot of authority and autonomy and

[00:26:52] responsibility to those students that remain on their roles in the local division thank you anybody else good morning um thank you all very much for being with us and dr parridge and i appreciate your graciousness and allowing your principal to serve with us here on our board so i want to start by saying that but i do have a question i noticed in the documents that there is an intent to develop admissions criteria i assume the board once it is seated will do that

[00:27:32] i this perhaps is not a question but just an acknowledgement that i would have concern or at least want to have a critical eye toward those admissions criteria that ensure accessibility for all students across your divisions and it not because you know that ultimately this great thing that you're trying to do becomes then an issue of access that disproportionately affects one group of students or another dr wilson i think that is a great point and our region

[00:28:06] our regional board will set a recommended criteria we also will use the department of education will be issuing recommendations in regards to senate bill 1303 and we will tie those in to our recommendations as well but at the end of the day admission will those final decisions even though we'll provide guidance will be made by the individual school divisions but it will be in conjunction with the regional board's recommendation and the Virginia Department of Education's Senate Bill 1303 recommendations as well. Thank you. I appreciate

[00:28:41] that. Dr. Wilson, if I may too, we have a draft enrollment eligibility criteria that we'd be more than happy to share with you. And of course, it is a draft until we know more about Senate Bill 1303, but Caitlin can certainly send that to Mr. Bowling and he can share that with you all if you would like that. I was going to switch on that as well. Yes, r7va.org is the website that we've developed.

[00:29:04] it's actually listed on that website r7va.org and you can um that that website will continue to evolve as as as this regional academy does but there is a link to that tentative enrollment and eligibility criteria there you'll notice at the bottom it does provide the flexibility for those individual divisions to allow students who maybe don't meet that criteria into the program so that we we keep that equity and access open there thank you i appreciate that and um you know so the the board itself and this the group of superintendents which has come together to to form this perhaps

[00:29:39] has an opportunity to lead in this area but we certainly know that individual divisions do what they need to do but uh where there's opportunity for leadership that would certainly be welcome and i'll go to that website thank you so no need to send it to me and um i think dr lane just put it here for us so thank you anybody else miss holton uh first uh congratulations on the work you all have done this fall uh yes we we are aware dr barrigan that you all have been both in for in person and virtual we we do have a source on uh what's going on in your district and

[00:30:15] uh we're i i can't imagine what it's been like to teach uh virtually this year for school divisions but school schools such as yours that are doing both i it's just beyond um imagination the the amount of work and innovation uh creativity is required and we're all just we bow down in appreciation and for the creativity involved in bringing bringing this matter to the fore it one first just a request that as you heard earlier we are going to be looking at the putting together regulations for virtual education in virginia virtual academies in virginia so

[00:30:56] get involved in that and help us get it right so that's my request my question is so i think i I understand correctly that the homeschool divisions are basically responsible for everything other than academic content. So you are absolutely going to still be providing everything from meals to counseling to watching out for dropouts, etc. And I applaud that model. I think that makes a lot of sense. In terms of the content, my knowledge of virtual education providers

[00:31:31] generally is that there's some good ones and some that are not so effective. And I have complete confidence in Virtual Virginia, and I see that you're offering a wide variety of, I think the entire Virtual Virginia catalog is in your catalog, as I understand it, will be in the catalog.

[00:31:50] I would appreciate hearing a little more about the other two providers, Edgenuity and now look but the name of the other one, but how did you go about selecting those and how, what can you tell us, oh, the STRIDE program, what can you tell us about their quality generally and about their ability to deliver the Virginia specific content?

[00:32:13] - I'll defer to Dr. Graham. He is the resident expert on the MOPS for us. - And I love also the collaboration with Radford. That's just, what a great, terrific, bringing people together you all have done. - Thank you so much.

[00:32:29] So the two other providers that we have, Stride and Edgenuity. Stride is a, you know, they started as a K-12. I don't know if that rings a bell to you, but they started at K-12 and Bob, Virginia Virtual, actually started in here in region seven.

[00:32:48] I think it was close to 20 years ago. They started in Carroll County with a remote learning program for one of their organizations that they had within their county. So they've been around for more than 20 years serving remotely in Virginia.

[00:33:04] They also are across the country, the K-12, which now is Stride. And you can go onto their website and see the variety of offerings that they have. But for curriculum-wise, they are very strong. We are partnering with them this year.

[00:33:22] We in fact had 11 students in Radford who are part of Virginia Virtual, but since we're partnering with them now, they actually are enrolled in Radford too. And I've spoken with the families of those 11 or 12 students and they're very happy with the learning platform that they provide.

[00:33:41] They do both asynchronous and synchronous learning. Now, Edgenuity, Ms. Holden, I'm not as familiar with. I know they are more of a credit recovery type of organization and moving into more of the full remote learning academic platform as well.

[00:34:01] So I don't know, I know Dr. Perryton uses them, I think Keith, right now, don't you? A little bit for credit recovery, but I'm not as familiar. As far as how we chose those two, we had, so once we had the board in place and we started to look at partnerships, we knew Virtual Virginia was gonna be one we wanted to have because we've had extensive experience with them and and brian is so easy to work with uh and of course they're part of the virginia department of education uh and then stride was was fairly easy because they've been a partner with us and they also are partners with

[00:34:40] five or six other divisions in in virginia and then edgenuity reached out to us they were kind of the first ones to reach out to us beyond the two that we already had uh and then once that happened it really morphed into a lot of a lot of organizations wanting to to be a part of this too but we simply didn't feel like that we needed more than three to be able to house the amount of students that we feel like we're going to have remotely next year when the 2021-2022 school year begins. So those are the three that we've chosen. We've met probably twice a week since we started

[00:35:18] this and they have just been wonderful. One of the things that they are pledging to us which we really appreciate and I think you all should know this is uh $50,000 to um our our curriculum instructional program which we have here in region 72 which will help us really make that even more more robust than it is and that's that's a a platform that we have to help us with um not only academics but data as far as as looking at that where our students are and the growth that they have I'll just add to to that Ms. Holton uh first of all I'd like to really thank Dr.

[00:35:53] lane for being creative as well and providing a pricing structure with virtual virginia that really made that an option and it also helped us as we were negotiating with the others and that was one of the big things that came out of this regional academy and robin you may need to mute because there's probably an echo i'm sorry that's okay um the it really helped us get competitive pricing our school divisions could afford this across the board and for example some school divisions will choose just one provider and it may be virtual Virginia for example I know I know some school divisions are going to go solely with virtual Virginia in Bristol we're

[00:36:29] going to use all three providers with the idea that some of our students are higher achieving we will probably assign them to virtual Virginia edge annuity has done a really great job in our alternative programs and with some of our students who need more support and so for those students we'll probably choose edge annuity and for those students who are in the middle of the road from an achievement standpoint we will probably use stride and so the amount of options that we have available to us because of this regional partnership are phenomenal and because the regional partnership also provided a pricing structure that for the first time really made

[00:37:05] significant virtual learning affordable to our high poverty school divisions so if i may just by way of a quick follow-up question that's all very reassuring and i hope and trust that you have built into your plans some monitoring for outcomes with each of the providers and you know academic outcomes but also well the immediate academic outcomes but also hopefully you know contributing to graduation rates and post-secondary rates if you if you build all that in from the beginning it will help you both evaluate the mix of providers you're using over

[00:37:44] time but also help us all evaluate virtual options generally yeah and that's a great just my impression of the national evidence is that some of these virtual academies work and some of them don't and so we want this to be one of the ones that does and the competition will help because i can assure you especially the mops they they really want our business and as we're looking at those outcomes i think that will help assure that we're getting a high quality service and product to our students because they want to be with us again in year two and so that will be

[00:38:21] definitely part of the monitoring process from a student standpoint but also from a program standpoint and will it'll help us hold those uh online providers accountable and and if i may too uh that's why we have caitlin as well caitlin's going to be not only monitoring the the partners that we have but she's going to be tasked with part of her job description is to make sure that all the divisions those remote students are doing well and if they are not doing well she's going to be the first contact uh for the superintendents to be able to reach out to to support uh those

[00:38:55] students and and we don't want to we've talked about this quite a bit we don't want to kick them out of the remote learning um you know platform the very first time but there's there's some some difficulties uh and she's she's wonderful with the relationships so she's going to jump in there and and see what she can do in order to provide support and hopefully get those students back on task.

[00:39:18] And the other thing I wanted to say too, with Matt Hurt in the curriculum instruction program, he's absolutely wonderful with data. And that's why these folks are partnering with him too, is so he can do his data analysis of the remote learning platforms that we have and tell us what we're doing well and what we need to improve on to.

[00:39:39] - Yeah, Dr. Mayne. - Yes, thank you. - Then Mr. Swan, I know your hand's up, but I'm going in order. dr man well thank you president gecker and thank you all for that great um overview and it is i shared the excitement that uh others have spoken to about this partnership and what it could mean for the region um my questions probably isn't so much a question maybe more so for dr lane because it's clear that as we've said this is this is a reality that's here to stay and while we've we've had to go in this direction under the conditions of covet to ensure that children are

[00:40:16] continuing to have access to education i think as we are being asked to really make decisions in this space around regulations i think it would be very very helpful at least for me not being as familiar with the research around distance education particularly for children on the k side um i would really love it if the board could have access to a summary of kind of what is the state of knowledge around um distance education and its impact for very young children we talk about screen time and development and the importance of social emotional and i i i just think

[00:40:55] that's going to be very helpful for me to kind of really make sure as we're setting structures in place we are really attending to um what we know about development and for the youngest children with use of technology at this level of intensity Mr. Gecker I'll just respond quickly if you'd like sure uh thanks

for the uh the question Dr. Mann and what I would say is part of the item that you uh approved with the withdrawal withdrawal earlier today opens up the door for us to explore a lot

[00:41:29] of that as a board but I will say that as it relates to the current requirements which don't necessarily address a lot of your questions uh the region seven proposal uh falls within that okay mr swan yes um i'm loving this idea of the virtual academy i just have uh kind of two questions i didn't see it in the attachments how would the teachers be selected and if veteran

[00:42:00] teachers were selected um what will be put in place in order to help them mr swan i i'm happy to take that question originally our original plan that we started with in october would be that we would hire our own teachers however when that morphed into partnering with virtual virginia and the on the multi-divisional online providers those groups will hire their own teachers and so but they will they're required to have the same credentials and criteria that a public school teacher that's teaching in person will have and so that we don't have a choice in selecting those

[00:42:38] teachers however we will have a hand in part of the evaluation process and then work with those teachers to ensure that students are being successful and I will piggyback on that in relation to miss Holton's question that that was one of the reasons we chose those programs is because they were Virginia approved MOPs and so we knew that their teachers would be you know highly qualified certified Virginia instructors thank you miss Holton just very briefly if I can uh follow up on mr swans when 50 billion years ago when my uh youngest child was in

[00:43:16] middle school she took a virtual virginia uh chinese course which never would have been something she could have taken at a richmond public school middle middle school but for that option and at that point there were actually two teachers involved so there was the chinese speaking online instructor but there was also a virtual virginia teacher whose job it was to do the in-person interaction both with my daughter and me and called me up to do parent-teacher conferences and met with, you know, graded my daughter's work, etc. So she had both the

[00:43:52] native Chinese speaker instructor and a Virginia, virtual Virginia employee who was doing all the student engagement work. It was a very impressive product. There were technology glitches then. But as I say, it was a billion years ago.

[00:44:15] What else? Yeah, I think I had just one question because I'm just trying to understand what the advantage of the joint school is when we're outsourcing essentially all the providers, you know, would have understood it if we were using division personnel and putting together something. Is it just bargaining power? I mean, what's the reason to do this if everything's outsourced mr gecker that bargaining power is certainly part of that but also by pulling our resources and being able to hire caitlin and potentially even expanding that to additional

[00:44:52] staff in the future that also takes the that that burden of overseeing the project off of the each individual superintendent and puts that burden on caitlin's lap and gives us a point of contact between the mops and virtual virginia and the individual schools and even students and families and so uh we also we hope to expand this into other areas in the future obviously we're going to take it one step at a time and just deal with the regional virtual academy now but we we see that there is we know in southwest virginia and all over rural virginia that together we're stronger and and by coming together like this it has really opened up a lot of doors

[00:45:32] to us that wouldn't be opened otherwise and so we're not only excited about the regional academy and the the power that it potentially possesses but we're just so excited about other potential things that we're even we're unaware of at this time and so that's that's to me i think that's the exciting part about this regional virtual academy all right that's helpful thank you because certainly other other jurisdictions just go ahead and do this individually so basically what you're saying is the accountability piece is what's important how many students do you expect to run through this and what's what do you think the profile of those students is well so i i can

[00:46:12] speak for bristol um we we anticipate uh having about 15 of our students currently we still we have about 25 of our students who are still choosing to learn virtually um based on surveys we anticipate maybe half of those wanting to stay in that environment and for the most part it is uh for student the students that are wanting to do it are for they still have health concerns in their home they're afraid that the child may get the virus and bring it back into the home but one other additional benefit that we think may occur from this and we've already had some inquiries is students who are choosing the home school route may decide to come back to public

[00:46:52] school if they have this virtual option and as a matter of fact in Bristol we're actually recruiting to that end to try to get some of those families back and so I don't know to what that's going to look like in other school divisions we're not sure but you know out of the 30 percent or the 25 percent that we still have in learning remotely half of those are doing very well and half of those are are struggling some and we're going to have to work really hard um to make sure that they're engaged regardless of what environment they're in if i may add too we we've sent out a survey already to our community and have about a thousand and of course we're really really small

[00:47:30] uh 1600 students but we've had about a thousand responses and 10 to 11 of our students are choosing to be remote next year and um caitlin has also sent a survey to all of the uh consortium members right now and so we're gathering that data um this year we had about 15 000 uh virtual learners in region seven i don't expect that that we're going to have that many but also talking with um brian and and suzanne at stride and howard at edgenuity their registrations for online

[00:48:06] learning is is up significantly uh so i think whoever it was that said it's going to be you know that the virtual is here to stay is definitely definitely true okay one more question if that's okay uh how do the financial incentives work here in other words does the division make money as you put more kids in the virtual.

[00:48:35] - Actually. - What's the benefit from the state to the locals and then what's the cost going out? I'd asked originally, I guess two weeks ago for a budget of how this works and we got a planning budget, but not really an operational budget for this.

[00:48:50] - Right, and so it's gonna work different for every school division. For example, Bristol, our locality barely gives above the required local effort. And so we don't have the same opportunities that other divisions will with MOPS to bring in students from outside our division.

[00:49:07] And so for us, we will pay, you know, whatever the per student cost is for students who want to go into the virtual environment. And then in year one and year two, we will use our ESSER funds or CARES Act funding to offset the cost to keep our staff in place.

[00:49:24] But as this process moves forward and we see the impact that it has, we will probably absorb some teaching positions through attrition as a result of that. But in the meantime, for the first couple of years, as we try to work on unfinished learning, we anticipate for the first couple of years that our class sizes will be positively affected in the in-person world because where we have the students that are going to the virtual academy, that will make those class size smaller and give our in-person learners more individualized attention.

[00:49:54] And so for us, from that standpoint, we will actually lose a little bit of our state aid because we'll be paying for the virtual classes, but we'll backfill with that with our ESSER funds. It'll look different in every school division. - Will there be an effort going forward, sort of a bad echo somewhere.

[00:50:14] Yeah, thank you, Dr. Graham. Will it be an effort going forward to bring kids back into the classroom? Everything we've seen so far seems to indicate that it's a better environment. - Absolutely.

[00:50:29] And when I hear you talk about years of running this, and like I said, it is here to stay, but the question is at what level? I'm not sure it's gonna become the preferred provision method for Virginia. - And I'll speak to that a little bit.

[00:50:44] Our enrollment and eligibility criteria is more strict than lenient because we do want students to participate in the academy if that's their least restrictive environment, if that's an environment that they're successful in. And so while obviously COVID is still at play to a degree, we've set that enrollment criteria such that, you know, if that environment is not working for that student, they will return to that in-person setting, which like you said, we do know there's significant research on that being a positive, you know, having an in-person teacher as well.

[00:51:15] So while it is an option and we've set this criteria in place, we do want only those students who are successful in that environment to continue in that method. - Okay, and how many people from outside the region do you expect to be enrolled in the joint academy?

[00:51:33] great question i'll take i'll take that so you're saying not non-resident students is that what you're saying president gecker um so we're expecting to have um around 5 000 non-resident students and just to be transparent with you because i think you all need to know this there is a uh for one of the organizations there's a 5.5 uh administrative fee for every non-resident students that were and i'm a rapid city is able to take those uh edge annuity is providing a higher percent than that uh and for example this year we we uh at the march 31st atm uh report we had

[00:52:08] 715 non-resident students which ended up being about close to 250 000 for us which really helped us and i know hold harmless would have helped us too but i didn't know that when we first signed on uh with them but that 250 000 has helped with the we in the beginning of the year we had lost 80 students and for a school division with 1600 that really is about i mean it's about a half a million dollars that we would have lost in ADM and and on top of that uh losing those students we want them here in Radford we want we want them in our public schools because we know how important like like you just said in person learning is is is you know the research says that that's that's the best type

[00:52:46] of learning that we can have especially with effective teachers yeah I know thank you very much Ms. Holton you had started to talk when I cut you off a little bit so you're okay all right Anybody else? Dr. Duran. Thank you. I was just going to make a comment as what was being said. I think that it's important to think long-term for distance learning to almost think about next year separate from the

bigger long-term vision of what it will look like because that for many families they are going to want to have next year distance learning for safety

[00:53:24] and health reasons or waiting for a vaccine and then there is a subset of parents though who do who have found this year to be a much more effective way for their students. So we've seen students, for example, with anxiety or social emotional disorders and things of that nature who have been thriving very well this year. So it's a smaller subset. And actually, there has been some research and discussion around that for those students having a distance learning as a preferred opportunity for them to learn. So we have to look at all students. So I know that, for example, in many divisions and in my division as we're providing this option for families we're actually

[00:54:01] asking them that question if they're choosing to want to be in virtual we're asking them why is it because of a preferred learning is it because of health and safety concerns of covet or is it that you're wanting to do this until your child has a vaccine so we're really trying to get that data and i think that would be good to get more of that data commonwealth across the commonwealth for next year why are families participating in virtual learning next year and then for that subset who are really participating in it because of it's a preferred learning experience and it actually helps their children be successful i think we need to think about that long term because across the commonwealth i don't think we have that as a focus for some of those students i've

[00:54:40] seen some other states that have before covet even been looking at students who have the preferred learning being in a distance so i hope we'll take advantage of that long term while also understanding that next year is still we're still in a pandemic we're still coming out of it there's still a lot of concern about what that looks like there are many communities who have been affected by COVID disproportionately than others who do not feel comfortable being yet many of them maybe don't even have access to health insurance and are fearful of getting that and no family members who have been impacted or even passed away in some cases so there's a variety of fears that are still

[00:55:19] going on right now and how do we manage and help families through that next year while also thinking long term what could distance learning look like for those other subset of students who it really truly is a better experience for them in that way i just wanted to comment on that and thank you dr peregin for your leadership on that dr wilson thank you um dr graham your comment about the business model has me thinking and this is not to get deep into the weeds of the business model however just as an observation with the eventual enrollment of non-resident students

[00:56:00] and the way that grows you know you are seeking to do this for the benefit of course of the 17 school divisions in your region but you know depending on how the business model then begins to grow right ripple out those providers may find themselves in a position of competing interest if you will and so ensuring that we keep our eye on region 7 students in virginia and not the 5 000 or whatever number of non-resident students i think will be something that certainly your board and individual school divisions will have to keep an eye on and as we get back to the

[00:56:39] issues of admissions criteria accessibility achievement teacher quality you know all of those things you know ensuring that that your divisions drive for you know in in in the spirit of our goals here in virginia you know just the business model makes me think about all of those details so just a comment not necessarily looking for a response but just letting you know kind of what's going on in my head as i i hear um a bit more about the business model so thank you i really appreciate that that's those are good

comments and those are something that we have have certainly discussed here too and you know all of my colleagues all the superintendent colleagues

[00:57:18] in region 7 accused me of stealing their students you know in region 7 and i can assure you that's not what we're trying to do we're really trying to help as many children as we can so dr wilson i really appreciate that comment and i appreciate the board's work as we tie this all back together on trying to get our soqs fully funded because when that happens the need to bring in outside students as a business model goes away and we can actually fund public education with the dollars that are there or should be there to fund the standards of quality yeah thank you miss halton

[00:57:55] yes sorry uh but uh i i do and dr wilson got at this a little bit but i i do i'm now understanding this differently if you're serving 1500 of your students and but maybe 5000 non-resident students i would hope that we could learn from your experience if you are monitoring outcomes for all of those students and if you're array and i should know better how the non-resident student model currently works and i don't know that but you know i hope you're working with um with those students to make sure someone is providing the counseling services and all the support services

[00:58:35] and and that you since you're responsible for for this group for this endeavor are making sure the outcomes are there for everybody not just for your resident students so and and we'll learn from your experience in ways that will help inform um others efforts in this in this regard so don't let the tail be wet you know if there's a tail and a dog anyway we want you to take care of both 5 000 students not just 1500. thank you and and if i can just give you an example of what we have done this year with our children that are non-residents that have ieps uh we actually put

[00:59:14] them on our caseload and are responsible for providing them with with the services that they they require so uh we've had meetings with those and know when their eligibilities are know when they know when we need to renew their IEPs. We've kept close contact with that and that's what we intend to do with our non-resident students too. And again, I don't have the experience with edgenuity. I do with Stride, but I meet with them almost weekly and talk about our non-resident students and how they're doing. So I appreciate that comment, Ms. Halton. Thank you.

[00:59:48] Okay. I guess at this point the board will accept this for first review. We'll see you guys in June. thank you very much for being with us today. I look forward to my next visit to Region 7. I'll tell you, it was fun last time I was down there. Thank you. Thank you. Thanks everyone. Good to see

[01:00:06] you. Okay. Item I, Ms. Malik. Good morning, everyone. Sorry for the delay. Sorry, you had me wondering if I had it right or not. I was going to... No, you had it perfect. I'll let Emily, I think, is going to start the presentation, but I'll go ahead and start. Good morning, President

[01:00:43] go ahead and start julie i'm trying to get it pulled up i'm sorry i'm not sure what's going that's okay i can i can double task too if you need me to so good morning president gecker vice president wilson dr lane and members of the board um i may have to pause in a moment but i'm just going to keep going for the time being i'm here today to discuss a proposed waiver for certain accountability and reporting requirements under the every student's excuse act and at this point

[01:01:17] i am going to emily i'm just going to go julie if you're able go ahead and share your screen i'm so sorry i'm the same problem as the other day i'm not seeing it but let me see if i can get it

[01:01:30] working yeah no problem hold on just a minute i'm having a similar problem let's see i've lost my

[01:02:04] controls let me try to make you a co-host here give me one second give that a shot all right

[01:02:34] good all right julie i think we're good to go now sorry about that that's okay now it's stopped hold on i i was um moving forward i think you can see my screen now perhaps julie we have emily

[01:03:00] screen up you're good to go okay fantastic okay um next slide okay thank you um so as a reminder the impetus of this request is from the 2020-2021 school year waiver that was um

[01:03:26] Karen DePauw: distributed and approved by the US Department of Education and this waiver canceled federal assessments for the year and had implications on federal identifications and. Karen DePauw: canceled a lot of the federal reporting as required for assessment just to note the first requirement does impact growth calculations for this year.

[01:03:53] We also wanted to explain that even though the federal identification requirements were paused for the 2020-2021 school year, those identifications were carried over from the 2019-2020 school year as per the waiver.

[01:04:09] So those schools continue to use services and resources this year off of the identifications from 2019-2020. Next slide, please. Okay, this may sound very familiar to you because back in January, I came before this board and presented the flexibilities and waivers available at that time.

[01:04:32] If you recall, this was through an addendum and a waiver process. This waiver and addendum process was aimed at two items. One, adjusting the measures of interim progress schools were expected to meet in the 2020-2021 school year. Essentially, we adopted, we were planning to adopt the targets that were set for the 2019-2020 school year, but with the absence of assessment, we were gonna move those targets to the expectations for the 2020-2021 school year.

[01:05:04] Also, the addendum and waiver process proposed shifting federal identification of schools by one year, thus not identifying schools again until the fall of 2020, or 2022, sorry. Soon after that meeting with you in March, the USED sent out a new set of waivers that they would consider through a federally developed template.

[01:05:26] These are the waivers that I'm going to present to you today. Next slide, please. The new waiver request was outlined for the board at your March board meeting by way of a report to the board. Soon after the March board meeting, this item was presented to stakeholders for public comment.

[01:05:45] That public comment period expired yesterday. So you will find public comments received prior to the board book being produced as attachment to today's board item. Comments received from April 10th through last night were provided to you this morning in a supplemental document.

[01:06:00] They include a meeting of the Virginia Committee of Practitioners and a presentation at the Principal's Conference conducted by the Office of School Quality, as well as a few other comments that were received in the past couple of weeks. Just a summary of those items, all comments and feedback received during the last 11 days were in favor of submitting the waiver in case you haven't had an opportunity to fully review that document.

[01:06:25] Next slide, please. mentioned before these waivers include accountability and reporting waivers so let's first review the accountability waivers um the first waiver that we would be seeking uh asks

us to again delay the identification of csi tsi and atsi schools based on 2020-2021 data so it was very similar to the addendum in the waiver process that was presented in january that we would not identify schools in the fall of 2021 the second item requests a waiver to the requirement that states measure

[01:07:01] schools progress toward the measures of interim progress as stated before the the addendum and waiver just sought to shift but we still had targets for the 2020 2021 data this waiver would remove those targets for the 2020-21 data and the measurements and the data accumulated this year would not be compared to those targets. And also a waiver on how participation rate would be used for assessments administered in the 2020-2021 school year. So those are the three

[01:07:36] requested waivers. Often when we work with USED, along with the waivers, with the acceptance of the waiver they offer, states must make certain assurances. So if these accountability waivers were accepted and approved, we would have to assure and ensure that the federal identifications of CSI, TSI and ATSI would again be extended and maintained for the 2021-2022 school year with all supports or with appropriate supports and interventions taking place during that year.

[01:08:15] We would also have to assure that this is, at this time, the last time that we would delay those identifications so that those identifications would resume in the fall of 2022 using data from 2122 next slide presumably now the requested reporting waivers look a little bit different in march of last year pretty much anything that had to do with assessment or accountability we did not need to report well the waiver opportunities in this waiver package

[01:08:50] waives the requirement for growth because again there's an issue with canceling spring 2020 data that does not allow us to measure growth according to our ESSA plan also we would not need to report accreditation ratings once again those accreditation ratings are waived again for the 2021-2022 school year so we wouldn't have those and also we would not have to report school progress toward the measures of interim progress and long-term goals. However, those accountability requirements would be waived, but there are accountability requirements that must be maintained if the waiver is improved,

[01:09:29] and that includes a publicly available report on achievement in reading, math, and science off of this year, a report on participation rates, a report on federal graduation rates, on English learner progress toward English language attainment and chronic absenteeism rates those are specific those are the items that are not to be waived next slide please and the assurance to go along with the reporting waivers states that receive this waiver must

[01:10:04] to the largest extent possible report on student and educator access to technology devices and high-speed internet at home. Unfortunately, the Office of Data Services was proactive and we are collecting this information at the student level, so the student level information would need to be reported if this waiver were approved by the USED. If the board approves, the VDOE would submit the waiver to the USED as soon as possible. Therefore, the Superintendent of Public Instruction recommends the Board of Education waive first review and approve the waiver request for a submission to

[01:10:42] the United States Department of Education. President Gecker, at this time I would happy to entertain any questions that you may have. Are there any questions by board members? I don't see any. Is there a motion to waive first review and request the waiver? So moved, Mr. President. Thank you, Dr. Duran. Is there a second? Second, sir. Thank you, Ms. Davis-Vaugh. By roll call, Dr. Wilson?

[01:11:10] Aye. Ms. Davis-Faught. Aye. Dr. Duran. Aye. Ms. Holton. Aye. Dr. Mann. Aye. Dr. Pexton. Aye. Mr. Swan. Aye. And I vote aye. Okay. We're at about an hour and change into this and we've got a, I guess, a chunk coming up that might be harder to break through. I'm going to propose a 10-minute break if that's okay with everybody and we'll see you all at 1120. Is that okay? Perfect.

[01:11:44] okay we're almost back dr pexton and miss davis vaught not quite uh she does need just a couple

[01:22:45] more minutes um i think we can that's fine you can probably go ahead and get started and not pop up for another couple minutes no thank you sir thank you thanks okay uh i guess we will move on to item j first review of revised guidelines for practice year one of the early childhood unified measurement and improvement system uh our favorite chief school readiness officer jenna conway back with us again good to see you a couple days in a row this is true mr gecker i i should note i'm the only chief school readiness officer so it's being favorited it's not a difficult test

[01:23:23] but i will take it i will take it not like that i'll tell you well there's many of those it's true it's true well good morning mr gecker superintendent lane and members of the board i am pleased along with miss carol and miss meyers to present to you all this morning the guidelines for practice year one of the early childhood unified measurement and improvement system i'd like to take you through a few slides that provide an overview you also have the guidelines

[01:23:56] document it's roughly 74 pages that in thorough and comprehensive detail goes through aspects of the why the what and the how with a real focus and improvement and as discussed in part yesterday a focus on the implementation so how we will work with providers across the sector in the commonwealth to support this implementation in practice year one emily if we can move to the next slide please As always, and I know you all are familiar and probably think I'm a little bit of a

[01:24:31] broken record here, but want to start with the why and what we are trying to achieve together. So as we discussed in part yesterday, and I know you've heard me come back to you and share information about this over the last year or so, we know our current early childhood system does not offer every child in the Commonwealth equitable opportunity. And we know that early childhood can work there is an extensive research base we heard from some colleagues yesterday on this point but too many families and children in the commonwealth lack access to these experience we also know when we put on our equity lens that our system too often fails to prepare children who

[01:25:08] are black hispanic speak a language other than english at home or have a diagnosed disability or developmental delay and so our proposal today really is a step and it's a key piece and i think I think as Ms. Davis Vought noted yesterday, access is another essential part of that, but really thinking about quality teaching and learning and how we can, as a board and as a department, support that across the sector.

[01:25:33] There'll be a theme to the content today, and you'll see throughout the document that together we must unify, might come up with a common expectation or true north and what we want for all children across our programs, family day home, childcare, Head Start, and school-based programs.

[01:25:48] about measuring um you know the kind of most important elements what matters most because we know what is measured is what is paid attention to and then really making sure that we are reorganizing our system based on what we're learning to support improvement so sort of similar to what we've talked about with the efforts around accreditation but really making sure that this is a measurement

and improvement system where where the focus is on supporting every educator so that he or she is best positioned to support the learning development of each unique child and the commonwealth you will also note before we move on to the next slide that the prioritize

[01:26:24] priority excuse me is for those who need it most and i think that's a shift from this system which was fragmented and fairly siloed to one where a lot of the measurement and professional development was focused on who sought it out rather than who might need it most and that's a pretty pivotal shift for the board and for our work. Emily, if you move to the next slide. I should note, and I promise I won't read every word on this screen, that this work builds on years of efforts around kind of thinking about quality measurement improvement at the national level and then here

[01:27:01] in the Commonwealth. And a lot of it, in order, we think, to be successful in implementing, we need to be building or basing our work on what is happening on the ground in the Commonwealth. And so the document today and part of the reason for its length and its comprehensiveness is that it is rooted in the experiences of actual educators across the sector over the course of the last few years with the culminating piece being the early childhood unification law that was passed and signed into law last year and that then requires this board, if we can move to the next

[01:27:33] slide, to adopt a uniform quality measurement and improvement system. So here is what is required of of the board so july of last year this law and you've heard me talk about the kind of key aspects of the law it required moving the oversight of everything related to early childhood so we've talked about the regulations that were on consent review this morning it required the creation of the early childhood advisory committee which became due all in january with that incredible membership of duly representative stakeholders from across the state and it requires the creation of the unified measurement and improvement system it calls you to establish it by july of this year

[01:28:12] which starts with these guidelines for first review today and then final review in June, but it's very clear that there should be at least two practice years. And so what we're talking about today is the guidelines for practice year one. These two practice years are really in response to the global pandemic and the kind of the impact that it has had on the early childhood sector.

[01:28:33] So initially the law only called for one practice year, but we worked very closely with the governor's office to make sure that we could allow for additional flexibility. By fall of 2023, all publicly funded programs will be required to participate with the goal being that the measurements would be shared in the fall of 2024.

[01:28:55] And so you would, you know, once we have these two practice years, we will get on a cycle that is similar to that of accreditation where we gather the data over the course of the year and then put out the results in the following fall. I should note that the law is very clear that this would include publicly funded programs, and that's defined in your guidelines, but that's basically any program that takes a public dollar to serve children.

[01:29:19] so it's not the food and nutrition program but really focused on the child care subsidy program which is a voucher that families can use to obtain child care whether in a family day home or in a child care center or a faith-based setting it includes head start and early head start and includes any early childhood programming virginia preschool initiative title one early childhood special education located in our public schools and that's covered in detail in the guidelines we have also as part of our broader efforts

and you'll notice throughout today as we're trying to make sure that everybody is aware of this have put together quite a bit of content on

[01:29:55] our website so that we can make sure that people know and are kind of aware as we're building this system Emily next slide please so in the next few slides I'm just going to highlight what is in the guidelines document and it really provides an overview it provides kind of the legal requirement who's in who's out and then it goes into detail on what will be measured and then kind of how we're supporting improvement so i'll speak first to what will be measured after looking at both what was happening nationally consulting with outside experts and then um you know focusing in on what

[01:30:31] was occurring on the ground in virginia our proposal is that we focus on two nationally recognized indicators of quality teaching and learning that can be measured in all of our early childhood settings the first of which is interactions which we know is a very strong predictor of child outcomes and we're proposing that we use the classroom assessment scoring system or the class which i know we talked a little bit about yesterday it's developmentally appropriate it was designed for infants toddlers and preschooler classrooms goes to k-12 as well but we would focus here on those younger ages and we are proposing that we look at the use

[01:31:10] of curriculum with this idea being that we know that our educators need support on thinking about intentionally what activities what content how to think about their days with infants toddlers and preschoolers we think these are the two when we talk about our guiding principles sort of the two most important indicators that can be measured at scale and can be we can get buy-in from educators and that are movable, I think as Dr. Basak and others talked about yesterday, and that these go hand in hand together. If we can support stimulating interactions that are warm

[01:31:47] and responsive, and we can support educators to be intentional about how they help children learn and grow in an age-appropriate way, an infant curriculum, as you might imagine, looks pretty different from preschool curriculum, that we can ultimately help and promote school readiness across the board in a way that is equitable and culturally responsive to all of our littlest learners next slide please this gives a little bit of the detail on kind of how we we went from looking at all the different ways in which one a state might measure quality down to the focus on

[01:32:26] on two um and this kind of gives you our our top our top five or top top four uh rationale i think kind of the the key ones i'll highlight from you one is that this can be used in all settings and if provided the right supports can be used equitably in all settings. Two, there are very strong correlations with promoting child outcomes and really something that's critically important. Three, these are materials that have been used in Virginia on the ground, and so that increases our likelihood of being successful and implementation. And then I think

[01:33:03] four is across these two really being thoughtful about the diversity of both our program settings as i talked a little bit about yesterday this is different from k-12 in many aspects in terms of who's providing these education and care services um you know the the constituency we tend to send serve those kids who are furthest from opportunity and being very thoughtful about how we are both culturally and linguistically responsive to these children and to their families is really critical and for those collected reasons these are kind of why we think these are the two most important

[01:33:38] things to measure. Next slide please. We also landed on these two measures because we believe that we want to structure a system and I'll talk a little bit later about how we'll provide resources to ensure

the success here but at its core to make sure that the system was structured to support improvement and a lot of that hinges on making sure that we build a system that gets information and supports down to the classroom level and that is a huge undertaking um in terms

[01:34:15] of kind of quite different from how a lot of these these systems right now work a lot of the professional development systems are kind of come as you go if requested uh tend to be a little bit more ad hoc sometimes we use samples of classrooms so we're not really focused on getting to every educator in every classroom every year but we sort of say we can generally get an understanding what's happening in a program by observing you know half of the classrooms every two years or every three years and that might be mathematically true right that might actually be an indicator of what's going on in that program but that is not as useful for every educator when you think about

[01:34:51] kind of every educator deserves feedback each job is individual um and um you know and we have a lot of turnover right and so we have to really be kind of paying attention on on a more specific basis so our system is designed to make sure that every educator receives feedback and then also receives aligned supports to improve their practice but it's a strengths-based system saying here's what you're doing well and that we are then aligning all of the millions of dollars that we spend on resources to make sure it meets their unique needs we want to empower program leaders this is really important but they also have that same information we're all working from the same

[01:35:31] sheet of music and they have the data and the information and the support to improve and that this entire ecosystem and this is that we bring all these fragmented providers together those that support professional development coaching training that they too understand what we are measuring why it matters and that we're aligning these improvement efforts and then once we look at all of that information and that data how to make sure that we prioritize those that are furthest from opportunity, least likely to receive the support. I also note that the law calls for really thinking about incentives for the system, and one of the really important pieces that we are

[01:36:08] tackling is that we know that you can make a lot of investments in professional development and coaching and support, but if 40% of your educators leave the classroom every year, that investment walks out the door. And so one of the things that Virginia has attached with its efforts around piloting over the last few years is a $1,500 annual direct to educator incentive. It is focused on educators who are not employed by school systems, so our family day home and child care educators in programs that take our public dollars, and we've seen already an impact in reducing turnover. I should also note, thanks to some of the COVID relief funding and knowing the

[01:36:48] extreme hardships faced by these educators, we were able to increase this amount to $2,000 this year so all educators who are receiving this incentive um will receive two thousand dollars and we have committed to any educator who is not employed by a school system who works um you know who's part of the practice year next year will receive an educator incentive of at least fifteen hundred dollars simply for being part of this so this is not based on the credential of the educator not based on sort of hitting a certain performance level this is simply based on being part of the practice year and kind of trying to kind of address this turnover issue while also recognizing that

[01:37:24] this is a pretty significant shift for some of our educators who may never have been part of something like this before next slide please so in the proposal we also talk in a little bit more detail about how we will look at results for um year one and we basically are going to take as i said before we are going

to fund communities to observe all classrooms twice a year um using this class system of measures and there's an infant version there's a toddler version there's a preschool version there's about a 90 minute observation various cycles and they look at

[01:38:01] everything from warmth and responsiveness so the emotional climate of the room how well it's organized how the educators support their behaviors in the classroom and in an age-appropriate way what kind of instruction looks like it can be used with any curricular material it really kind of is a more abstract measure of kind of supporting critical thinking skills use of language We will then take all of that data from all of the classrooms and then kind of average that together.

[01:38:28] So if you have infant and toddler classrooms, it would include both. If you're just preschool, it's just preschool. We will then also look at whether you're using approved curriculum in at least one classroom. And when we look at the current landscape of where curriculum is being used, it's a little noisy, but we are hesitant to require that across the board.

[01:38:47] we really want to kind of start small and support the field to make sure that at least one of their classrooms in the beginning that they're using an approved curriculum and for doing that they will receive 100 out of 100 points as part of their score we will then add up those interactions points and those curriculum points and that will be your total score we have to have a rating as required by the law and we've we have gone back and forth on this we initially when we took this to the early childhood advisory committee had exemplary satisfactory and needs improvement and folks felt like that just didn't seem appropriate with the context of a practice year

[01:39:27] with the kind of the the size of this this group and really what we were wanting to achieve which was kind of information for all programs but not not having this this this reading that that felt like it it could imply more than that so we have revised those based on feedback and if we have our programs that we think really need to be prioritized for supports instead of saying they need improvement saying what they need to do is to be supported right and kind of identifying that for a group that in the in the middle that really meets our expectations for the practice year just saying that directly and then for those subset of classrooms um and programs that are

[01:40:03] just you know have made incredible investments um in quality over the the past year and really can serve as as models for programs across the state noting that they are doing exceptionally well and and that they exceed our practice year expectations. So again, a shift in real time based on our feedback from the field and folks who are doing this work as part of the pilot.

[01:40:26] Next slide, please. So let's talk for a little bit about the improvement question. And as I noted yesterday, Dr. Duran, I promised though that I would come back to this, but the really thinking about how we're structured to support improvement, and then I'll talk in a second about direct resources there.

[01:40:46] So these are practice year results, we would not share these with anybody, but our real goal is to build a system across those communities that receive funding to do this work in practice year one, so that first off, everybody understands what is being measured and why.

[01:41:01] We then have a systematic effort, and all of the communities that are participating receive funds to make sure that they can build the capacity to have these certified observers. So as we said before, it's a national certification, a two-day training, and you have to pass a test in which you observe videos and demonstrate that you are reliable to a certain degree.

[01:41:20] And so really making sure that we have enough capacity to get those observations done and that those observations are happening in the fall and spring. As a condition of the dollars that go out to the communities, being very clear that it's not just about getting the observation done, but that all of the educators in the classroom need to receive feedback with a focus first on strengths.

[01:41:39] And we've done a lot of technical assistance and professional development on giving feedback, and there'll be more of that to come, but making sure that we're helping educators understand first their strengths and then their opportunities from growth. Then working with the field around, well, how do you take that information and what do you do with it?

[01:41:55] And how do you sort of say, let's build on your strengths, let's identify the areas for growth and how we can support that. And we're working very intensively right now with the array of providers across the state that we fund to do professional development to align that. And then we will get the fall data, we will get the spring data, we will look at, we'll take a kind of an equity approach to the analysis there.

[01:42:15] we'll look at sort of who's doing well, who's struggling, how we have used our improvement resources to support programs, where we have done that well, where there are gaps, and we will come back to you next spring with potentially any shifts to the guidelines for practice year two. And then we'll do the same in practice year two, come back to you again.

[01:42:33] So, trying to do this cycle of continual improvement at the state level, at the local level, and down to the program level. Next slide, please. I want to kind of come back to the slide that the colleagues presented yesterday just on the kind of, again, importance of recognizing that we know our educators are finding this useful, and I think as we think about the practice year, it is, again, opt-in, and also talk in a second go. We're really making sure that we're prioritizing resources to support our communities, our program leaders, and our educators next year. We do think

[01:43:12] that there is promise in us being able to work with the field so that they truly can find this be a measurement and improvement system that benefits my ideal for this is that a few years now will reflect back and educators remember this as for many times the first time that they received feedback they also received a direct incentive right they just recognized them for being in the classroom and for some of the the new tasks that were put in in front of them and they see how this can benefit kids and again i had that powerful experience of being able to observe that on the the ground in Louisiana. And I think this initial data that Dr. Bisak shared yesterday suggests as

[01:43:48] such. I want to note that the question came up yesterday about, you know, what about some of the programs that haven't benefited from this in the past? How do they feel about this? And just to note that the dark orange and light orange bars are our child care centers and our family day homes that are participating in the preschool development grant. This is 2,000 educators from across the state, and they found that it was useful to focus on class even during COVID.

[01:44:15] We, in fact, think that their numbers, right, so 83% of them and 85% of them thought that was useful, are higher potentially than schools in Head Start because they've had to be in person, right, and they just recognize the importance of these interactions, particularly when our kids and our educators are facing an upside-down world.

[01:44:33] So I wanted to put this back in front of you, noting that I think to the questions raised about implementation, that we will continue to do this survey and continue to really ask that question of our

educators. Because if it's not useful for them, then we know we're not going to get buy-in around change. And we know it's not going to be actually helping their practice.

[01:44:51] And that's what we have to kind of center in this work. So we think this is a good start. I'd like to see those numbers higher, right? Like above 90% across the board, right? That they think interactions are important, that they understand what is being measured and why, and that they think that this focus is useful for them, because if it's useful for them, we know that it means that they are really using it in support of their children's learning and development. Next slide, please. So the key piece on the implementation, and there's sort of two aspects that I wanted to

[01:45:26] note here to some of the points raised yesterday, Dr. Duran, I think one, we need to resource this, like we need to put real dollars towards supporting this to happen. And so we are directly funding our communities to build relationships, to conduct these observations. We look at the number of classrooms they have, and we fund them based on that, and to support educators, right? And then our kind of providing TA to those communities, measuring every step of the way through Link B5, you know, able to kind of see, all right, are the observations happening or not? You know, are educators satisfied or not through the survey? So really putting resources, real resources in

[01:46:02] terms of dollars and staff towards that. We also recognize that quality is not just a function of like what you pay your consultants and your professional development, but actually what you pay your programs directly. And so we were very pleased to have a higher Virginia preschool initiative rate. We have increased the rate for mixed delivery this year going forward. And I think in partnership with you, we will come back and continue to look at raising the rates, the child care subsidy program really in recognition as Dr. Mann and others have noted that we need to be funding programs to meet these health, safety, and quality expectations. Those rates were increased a year and a half ago, but we're still hearing from the field pretty directly that they are

[01:46:42] insufficient as it relates to the actual cost of providing care and education. We currently spend just under $20 million only directly on improvements. These are not dollars towards slots. There's an appendix of all of this too in the document at the end, but making sure that we are aligning those resources and we are taking the data and prioritizing those who need it most.

[01:47:03] So one example is we have a mental health consultation program. We will be using some of the federal funding to expand that next year and looking specifically at those programs that, you know, based on initial observations might need support and supporting that's an intensive coaching intervention where you go in, you work with the director, you work with the educators, You talk about the children's behaviors the educators are finding challenging, really kind of in a long evidence base on that it helps change day to day practice for educators, for kids, and for programs.

[01:47:38] Similarly, we'll be looking at direct investments in curriculum, first understanding what people are using. We don't want people to switch if they're using something that's that's quality, reviewing curriculum materials, and then making sure that curriculum is not unaffordable to programs. And then lastly, you can hear me talk about this before, but this incentive directly to our educators.

[01:48:00] Next slide, please. So lastly, just in terms of the engagement, and then I'd love to open it up for questions. So as required by law, we now take anything that we are going to bring to you to our early childhood advisory committee in advance.

[01:48:16] We did, after an incredible three hour meeting, receive an endorsement with three recommendations from the early childhood advisory committee, all of which are reflected in your documents. documents. So the first of which is they asked for families to be considered as a guiding principle. And so we added the seventh guiding principle around that making sure that this system serves as a resource for families, right? It sort of recognizes the cultural and linguistic diversity of our families is useful to them and includes them as kind of key stakeholders as well.

[01:48:51] The second was that we needed to really strengthen our improvement section. So there was a much longer section looking at all the current improvement resources, how they'll be aligned, and noting explicitly that we prioritize our family day homes and our child care programs that often have been under-resourced in the past. That's really page 51 onwards. And then lastly, looking really specifically at inclusion. We have an incredible teacher from our public schools who talked about he actually teaches in an inclusion classroom and was concerned about the extent to which we're looking at some of those inclusive practices and so we'll pilot this year using

[01:49:28] a specific measure along with the class to look at those interactions and that will help us get better data on the extent to which we need to go beyond the class when we're thinking about inclusionary classrooms we also did an online survey with the full document and again we capture this chart just captures some of the strengths and the questions and concerns many of which we tried to address, you know, between the feedback and between the advisory committee.

[01:49:55] But I think the key things are some of the things that came up yesterday. How do we make sure we communicate this effectively? How do we not recreate the wheel, but build on existing partnerships? How do we prioritize our family day home providers? How do we think about work in other languages? And then I think continuing to make sure that there's not a cost, right?

[01:50:17] this is not a pay to play system, but that we are using particularly the federal dollars to address those costs so that it truly is a more level playing field for our providers. With that, let me pause there and see what questions there have.

[01:50:36] If not, the superintendent would recommend that the Board of Education receive for first review the guidelines for practice year one of the Early Childhood Unified Measurement and Improvement System. well thank you for the complete presentation uh are there any questions uh dr wilson thank you um jenna thanks for the presentation just a quick question the reference to the cost for class i don't recall seeing that and i don't know that it came up in our work session on

[01:51:07] wednesday so what is that cost uh generally speaking yeah so it varies dr wilson so there's a cost um to kind of get an observer trained right and and depending on kind of how many observers um and that's fairly expensive um you know it kind of could range from just under a thousand dollars to um slightly over that depending on if you if you do that individually or you do that as a group not if that that is not for every teacher and that may not even be for every leader um that's just at the kind of community level and then the additional cost is uh that it often sort of costs

[01:51:46] for somebody to do an observation it just takes time so once you're trained as an observer you don't have to pay every time but it does it does take your time so we fund to the degree of several hundred dollars per classroom to get all of these done and that is funded to the community level so there should not be any kind of out-of-pocket cost for an individual program thank you anybody else uh mr swan yes thank you so much um for the presentation just a quick question will the

[01:52:21] teachers within these early childhood settings have to be highly qualified as if they were in a in a regular school building so one of the things we've tried to be very thoughtful about is you know there are different credential or qualification requirements across these settings and so there for instance you do not have to have a bachelor's degree and a virginia teaching license if you teach in a child care center or in a family day home right which is a a difference from what is

[01:52:56] required in in a school program for your school employee um head start has a has a separate set of requirements that come from from the federal level we looked at um and many systems mr swan do include a credential requirement right and it looks both at like do you have a license and sometimes there's even kind of additional qualifications um and we are cons we we purposely did not include that um for two reasons one is that does not reflect our current universe right now we think about half of our family day home educators for instance um do not have um only

[01:53:34] have a high school degree right and so to kind of require a bachelor's degree would put them out of of business, right? Like they couldn't do that. The second is we were able to take the data from Virginia and look at interaction quality, right? So look at these nationally recognized observations of what was actually occurring in classrooms and credential. And what we saw is that it ranged and so that there were individuals who could do an incredible job of writing high quality interactions to infants and toddlers, for example, and who also, you know, who had a high school degree or who had an associate's degree. We had a child development associate. And so we were, we would, and if we had

[01:54:14] put in, you know, a credential requirement, it would have basically said, well, this group, you know, would be considered lower quality, even though the actual interactions in those classrooms or in those settings would have been considered high quality. And so for that reason, we ruled that out as a, as a, as a kind of a, as a requirement of this system. So it doesn't change any of the the program requirements like the sort of code still says if you work in a school system you have to have a teaching license the federal law still says head start has to have this expectation so it doesn't change that but it does not include credential or qualification

[01:54:52] as as as part of this measurement and system because of um what we found based on the virginia data thank you anybody else not thank you again jenna oh i'm sorry miss holton thank you uh great work and great presentation jenna uh uh the reduction in turnover um i'm curious and that's focusing on that this fifteen hundred dollar per educator incentive i think is a wonderful thing

[01:55:28] recognizing the low pay that child care workers get the turnover percentage is not surprising but as you point out, and it's absolutely crucial, not just because of professional development, but relationships, everything we know about child development, figuring out how to have lower those turnover rates.

[01:55:52] I'm curious if anything in your Louisiana experience tells us how to help reduce turnover. And I'm curious whether measuring turnover is something we should be adding on to a criteria, Recognizing that turnover may be high, but are there things we can do to nudge it down and incentivize?

[01:56:15] And my guess is that some of the sectors have higher turnover than other sectors. Some of that's related to pay, but some of it may not be. So what can we do about turnover in our measurement or otherwise? Yeah, no, it's an excellent question.

[01:56:31] So let me start with the second question, and then I'll come back to it. So we are measuring it. So part of what's unique about providing these incentives is that they require verification. So oftentimes when you look at turnover, you do a survey at the end of the year and you ask leaders how many folks left, right?

[01:56:49] And then it's a ballpark, but that's why you, you know, when asked, early childhood folks will say, oh, it's 40% or it's, you know, anywhere from 25 to 40%, which is a pretty big range. But we have very specific data because we cut checks to these educators, right? And so we are, Ms. Hulton will be able to track this really specifically, and we will be able to kind of track both the kind of what we know about what's happening in classrooms to these turnover rates. We also, in aggregate, something that they have tracked in Louisiana and that we will also be able to track in Virginia is are educators leaving to go to other settings, which could be promising, right, if somebody kind of gets a credential and

[01:57:26] wants to become, you know, go on to a sort of a place where they can make more money, like nobody wants to hold that against an educator. Unfortunately, what they found in Louisiana was these are not our educators are not leaving to take higher up positions within the education early child education system they're leaving to go to target or walmart because or amazon which is you know paying 15 an hour and benefits start on day one right and so but we will we will at least be able to to to track that and to be able to bring you know more more insights there um we learned in year one we did actually provide incentives to school-based teachers and we

[01:58:01] basically saw no impact right so why we saw you know cut in half by turnover for family day homes and for child care educators we still know no impact for school-based programs and so in year two and going forward we're no longer providing those incentives so that we can actually provide more dollars to child care and family day home educators so that's a perfect example of measuring and then making adjustments based on where this is working um so i'm sorry can i interrupt did you say you did see an impact in the family day homes and the centers from you saw a significant impact on turnover from the incentives in in the pilot did i understand we did yeah so that's so it went

[01:58:38] from like we it dropped it cut it in half right from like i think there's like 30 to 15 in child care and family day homes and we saw almost no effect in the schools right so um which is partly why we've been in year two uh stopped providing those incentives to the schools and provided so and this is um to be clear if who your employer is right so we we know we have some programs that are physically located in schools but if you if you're whether you work for head start or vpi if you are a school-based employee we know that you generally make more money and you have full benefits if you are located in a licensed uh child care center or family day home um then we we continue to provide

[01:59:17] the incentive because we saw such a positive effect in year one um and we we are uh testing this year more frequent payments and also texting educators to help ensure that they understand what's going on and then we are currently looking at um potentially even increasing the funding over time um as a way to like sort of the ultimately if you stay a second year or third year like you know do we increase the incentive um you know largely to sort of to think we cannot make up the entire gap right between 10 and 12 an hour to you know a sort of a livable wage and full benefits but

[01:59:55] We think we can have an impact and we can get these dollars directly to educators, we did something similar in Louisiana with tax credits. The tax credits prior to rolling out the uniform system

were solely focused on credential so entry level was a CBA associates bachelor's degree and master's degree, and you know.

[02:00:15] The sort of a master's degree is often sort of unaffordable from for many, many, many early childhood educators, so we switched it there to reward retention. um and i've seen sort of some impact there in terms of really saying if you stay one year two years three years um i will be candid i think we need to do two things anything when you get dollars directly in the hands of educators and we need to kind of increase the rate right so that programs can actually be supported and empowered to address the full costs um you know nobody's making money at all in the sector right so it's but but it's like kind of doing those both things

[02:00:53] figuring out how we get programs enough you know and in the interim also making sure we get these dollars directly to educators and that we are doing that in a way that recognizes them brings sort of more prestige and professionalism to their work right and as i think we talked a little bit about yesterday this is the biggest change for them i'm not sure there's a huge you know a huge change for many of our our vpi programs they've been observed using these tools you know for years now but if we think about you know an and and you know on top of the fact that our family day homes right 80 to 90 of them stayed open every day throughout this pandemic really recognizing

[02:01:29] and supporting them um uh throughout this is critically important if i may just briefly that's really exciting to hear about the impact and it's not so surprising that we would have more impact family day home and child care centers because those educators are paid so much less that fifteen dollars was a bigger hit a bigger positive hit for them um but um so that's great to hear about the positive results but my question is what about adding this in as uh one of your um as part of your unified measurement and improvement system and i guess that would the question would depend

[02:02:08] a little bit on whether you think the operators of these um of the child care centers etc are part of are they part of the solution on attracting or on retention and turnover or is it all just the dollars in which case you know the more direct incentives is the the major part of the solution but do you want to know they yeah entities and give them points for reducing um turnover i will say we absolutely see them as like central right and and that they're kind of they not only are

[02:02:48] thinking about sort of who they're hiring, how they're supporting their educators, who's responsible for thinking about kind of professional development support, the walkthroughs they do, right? The leader is just the lunch pen to kind of this idea of, you know, supporting improvement in practice.

[02:03:06] And so we absolutely see them as essential. We've spent a lot of time looking at this data really carefully i have both in louisiana and and here in these early stages and we'd be hesitant to kind of attach retention directly to this when we looked at the data in louisiana we saw an interesting trend where there were three groups right miss hilton there was the group of leavers right the teachers that left there there were the stayers and they were the new teachers and interestingly enough as you might expect the stayers did the best when you look at interactions right when you And you looked at all their class scores across the board, infant, toddler, and preschool.

[02:03:45] But what happened over time in Louisiana is that those directors got better at hiring because the new entrants actually did better than the leavers, if you know what I'm saying. So there's like you always want to be careful about retention because you don't certainly 40% sort of turnover is terrible.

[02:04:02] But like there's some healthy turnover, right, in terms of kind of really thinking through who are the kind of folks who should be supportive. So we think that data was very promising. One, that those who stayed were getting supported over time to kind of get better and better.

[02:04:18] And two, that those leaders got better about thinking about who would fit there. So I think we'll continue to measure carefully, but I would be hesitant to kind of to have that entirely on the shoulders of the site leader. I think the other thing is, you know, if you talk to a site leader, they know, right, how you keep somebody.

[02:04:40] you pay them more right they just don't have the resources and the only way to pay them more is to turn around and charge their their families who are already struggling to kind of pay this to charge them more right so we don't want to create a system that says the only way to do well is you gotta you gotta somehow generate more money right and that and again that's this kind of idea of pay to play so i'm not sure that's exactly the answer you look for we will measure it very carefully we will when we can pay for it do it um and we'll look at it but we just don't want to sort of say to the site leader like you have to come up with more money in order to be successful

[02:05:12] in this system makes total sense thank you anybody else don't see anybody so jenna i'll thank you and uh the board is happy to take this on first review we look forward to uh seeing it again next month or in june thank you okay thank you all all right from early childhood to legionella sort of a weird uh transition uh item k first review of guidelines for water management program

[02:05:47] to prevent Legionella pneumophila growth in public school buildings. Somewhat reminiscent of the old Shark Commission for those of you in Virginia politics long enough to remember that one. Ms. Holton probably, no. Look that one up, that one's worth looking up. The Shark Commission, Governor Gilmore. In any event, Mr. Dickey. Thank you President Gecker. Good morning President Gecker, members of the board and Dr. Lane. This item is first review of guidelines for a water management program to prevent Legionella pneumophila growth in public school buildings

[02:06:26] and this is essentially developing a preventive maintenance program to guard against the risk of bacterial growth in major water systems that may be present in public school buildings such as cooling towers potable water uh showers a variety of you know standard water systems in public schools uh if not properly maintained um are at risk of of this type of bacterial growth

[02:07:00] and senate bill 410 uh from the 2020 session required doa doe to make recommendations for establishing maintenance and validation of water management programs to prevent this kind of bacterial growth and public school building water systems and we're required to develop recommendations by July 1, 2021 and these proposed guidelines before you today are intended to meet that legislative requirement. Senate Bill 410 also requires local school boards to have water

[02:07:39] management programs in place for their schools by July 1 as well and these recommendations will help facilitate that. In creating the proposed guidelines, DOE has worked with Department of Health Office of Drinking Water staff who have expertise in this area. We've also held discussions with industry representatives and a strong component of the guidelines are the best

[02:08:15] practice references from the CDC various other federal agencies as well as the primary industry standards for water management programs from the from from the primary industry group in this area that's the 188-2018 uh document that's referenced at the end of the guidelines uh really that that

uh resource as well as the cdc uh are really the authoritative uh sources of information and guidance uh in this area and it's a strong component of the draft guidelines we've

[02:08:55] put together uh today the board is requested to waive first review and approve um the proposed guidelines and and following board approval uh the guidelines will be uh posted on the virginia regulatory town hall as required for the 30-day public comment period under the apa uh after we uh after that 30-day period uh any comments received will be reviewed and incorporated as appropriate in the final document and we will make that public and communicate uh

[02:09:27] the final recommendations to school divisions by July 1. We're also planning in conjunction with VDH staff to conduct a technical assistance webinar for school divisions to review the final guidelines and review again with them the requirements of Senate Bill 410 and we want to get that done prior to July 1. The Superintendent of Public Instruction recommends that the Board of Ed waive first review and approve the proposed guidelines for water management program to

[02:10:04] prevent Legionella pneumophila growth in public school buildings. And I want to thank V.J. Rahman Rain who's director of support services in DOE for leading the effort to draft the guidelines and working with VDH staff and doing so and VJ's on today with us as well in case there are technical questions. Thanks President Gehrer. Thank you so much. Any questions? None. I will

[02:10:42] say it is an artful way of saying just do your jobs to the localities uh you made it seem very nice so thank you for that whoever did this drafting uh it is always interesting for me to see you know the tension between local control and state control and how this one ended up somehow in our laps i mean this is a if ever there were a purely local function this is it but we will do do what we're asked to do.

[02:11:08] Is there a motion to waive first review and approve this? - So moved. - Thank you, Dr. Mann. Is there a second? - Second. - Thank you, Dr. Wilson. Dr. Wilson? - Aye. - Ms. Davis-Vaught?

[02:11:26] Oops. Dr. Duran? - Aye. - Ms. Holton? - Aye. - Dr. Mann? - Aye. - Dr. Paxton? - Aye. - Mr. Swan? - Aye.

[02:11:41] - Did I hear Ms. Davis-Vaught say aye? - Yes, sir, aye. - Thank you and Chair Bozai. Thank you guys very much for being with us and appreciate your work on that item. - Thanks very much. - Item L, first review of revisions to the list of 2021-22 Board of Education approved industry certifications, occupational competency assessments and professional licenses.

[02:12:06] Mr. Wilcox. - Good afternoon, President Gecker, members of the board and Dr. Lane. As required by board regulations, the Office of Career, Technical and Adult Education presents the additions to and deletions from the list of industry certifications, occupational competency, assessments and professional licenses to meet the requirements on pages C through H of the board agenda item.

[02:12:44] In summary, these industry credentials apply to students that enter the ninth grade prior to 2018-19 and to students that enter in school year 2018-19 and be beyond there are three key points i would point to pertaining to students that entered prior

[02:13:14] to 2018-19 these are students who complete who must complete a cte program sequence of courses and pass an industry credential which may substitute be used as a substitute uh for the industry verified for the verified credit or two either used either for a laboratory science

[02:13:46] or history and social science verified credit any one board approved certification will satisfy the standard diploma graduation requirement for the cte crud crud credential and third students pursuing the advanced studies diploma may utilize additional tests for entering for earning verified credit in computer science, technology, career and technical education, economics,

[02:14:23] or other areas as prescribed by the board for verified credit. With respect to those students that entered the ninth grade in 2018-19 and beyond, a laboratory science verified credit may be awarded to students who complete a CTE sequence of courses and pass two approved industry

[02:14:54] recognized certification exams or professional licenses or one of each certification and license two in accordance to the standards of quality students shall i complete an advanced placement honors international baccalaureate or dual enrollment course to complete a high quality work-based learning experience as prescribed by the board guidance on work-based learning

[02:15:32] or three earn a career and technical education credential approved by the board three students are eligible to earn board of education approved seals for career and technical education and fourth students may receive other seals or awards for exceptional academic cte citizenship or other

[02:16:05] exemplary performance in accordance with criteria defined by local school boards. It should be noted that industry certifications are continually being revised or discontinued and new ones created to stay current with technology and new skills and techniques in the workplace and to ensure that credentials are relevant and recognized by business and

[02:16:41] industry as listed on pages i through j of item l 12 credentials have been added and 13 credentials have been discontinued by the provider and no longer offered these adjustments will result in a total of 454 board approved credentials the uh board approved number uh prior to

[02:17:16] this pending action was 455 the superintendent of instruction recommends that the board of education waive first review and approve the 12 new industry certification examinations occupational competency assessments and professional licenses to meet the board of education's requirement for one graduation effective for students who entered the ninth grade

[02:17:50] prior to 2018 school year two requirements for graduation effective with students who entered the ninth grade in 2018-19 and requirements for the career and technical education advanced mathematics and stem seals further that the board approved the removal of the 13 credentials

[02:18:20] which are no longer offered by the pro pro batter okay thank you mr wilcox um is there any questions on this item pharaoh as always so uh is there a motion then to wave first review and adopt dr pexton you're a second second thank you miss davis vaught uh dr wilson

[02:18:51] hi miss davis vaught hi dr duran hi miss holton hi dr mann hi dr pexton hi uh mr swan and i vote Aye. Okay. Thank you very much. That moves us down to item M, progress towards implementation of the recommendations from JLARC. And who's got this? Dr. Hollins. There we go. Okay. Welcome.

[02:19:27] Good afternoon, Mr. Gecker, Vice President Wilson and board members and Dr. Lane. I'm Linda Rivia and Dr. Hollins and I will share the presentation opportunity this afternoon regarding the JLARC reports. I'm pleased to report that the agency staff has been working diligently on the many recommendations. And so today, you may remember that in the last quarter of 2020, JLARC provided three reports to the public. In October, there was a review of the Virginia Department of Education.

[02:20:04] In November, there was a review of the Children's Services Act program. And in December, there was review of the k-12 special education services so i will begin our presentation with the information relative to the virginia department of education and then pass the baton if you will to dr holland so that she can provide you with information relative to the other two jlark reports next slide please while i am excited to share with you that there were 59 recommendations and policy options today we're just going to focus on the ones that we feel are most germane to the board

[02:20:42] and i know that you have the opportunity to look at all of them however we wanted to honor your time today and really bring up information relative to the items that you may have to act on in the future or that were required general assembly action that then might revert back to directives or mandates for the agency with reference to the board so we will provide information briefly and then it's also important to note that some of these recommendations that the agency is working with are are being impacted by other entities beyond their control

[02:21:21] of the agency so for example we work with vita many of you are very familiar with vita and their processes which have delayed some of our work but I would like to say publicly that we're appreciative of Dr. Lane and his efforts with Dr. Myers to work with the VEDA leadership to hopefully help us advance on some of the recommendations that are agency specific so that we can show good faith in responding to the JLARC reports. So next slide, please. So in 2018, JLARC approved a resolution directing staff to review the Virginia Department

[02:21:57] of education and you might ask why would this be the case it's because it's a large state agency and it plays a critical role in educating virginia's children and it had not been reviewed by jlark in many years and you may be aware that jlark does um review state agencies over time in a cyclical process so it was our time to have this review so again we did provide this report to you back in january but today we want to talk about the specific work that's been done in the agency relative to that those reports so this in this slide you're seeing why the slide was required

[02:22:37] and why was the study commissioned so in order to complete the report jlark staff undertook extensive reviews of agency documents and procedures they conducted a survey of department staff they interviewed staff and they conducted focus groups all of which to try to give them a comprehensive picture of the agency its processes as protocols and just underscore again because the agency has such an impact on all of Virginia's citizens an important process to

[02:23:09] undertake so please next slide in doing this there were several study findings and you will see that overall these findings were positive but they also included specific recommendations in areas that you might expect from such a study key areas fell primarily in the areas of support and supervision of school divisions school improvement programming and several components related to the recruitment and retention of a diverse and highly qualified staff for our schools next slide please so as i shared earlier dr hollins and i are not going to go through every single recommendation

[02:23:49] or policy option but we are going to highlight a few that fall under the purview of the board as well as those that may require general assembly action so first bullet here you will see that the agency staff are developing a work plan to extend current procedures that we have in place relative to the compliance of school divisions and meeting the standards of quality and the second bullet you will see the functionality the agency's website is really critical in order for school divisions to have access to support and information necessary to guide their day in day out operations

[02:24:26] and also for the stakeholders of Virginia to be able to get the information that they're seeking so the communication staff is working diligently to determine what might be a way for us to better create a website that is more intuitive as well as including a calendar of professional development events for educators across Virginia so they may know what those events are and get those on their own calendars early. Mr. Bolling is working with the virtual Virginia staff to potentially use an LMS learning management system that all of our educators have access to an

[02:25:04] account as a way that we might be able to share the calendar professional development easily to all school divisions and all educators and then finally not wanting to take the thunder away from Dr. Ortiz and newly Dr. Dreyer because the presentation following this one is very much an in-depth presentation regarding school improvement but continuous improvement processes have been part of the agency's work for years and the office of school quality has been reviewing and revising current practices and will provide you additional information in their presentation. So

[02:25:42] I want to honor your time and also defer to Dr. Ortiz and Dr. Dreyer as I know they're going to give you very extensive information relative to the progress on this recommendation around school improvement models. So the next three recommendations that you see on your slide are relative to first data we collect a tremendous amount of data at the agency and you as a board are seeing much of that data and reports throughout the year so while the school divisions are required to provide a variety

[02:26:17] of data points the jlark study was really focusing on what might be additional data or how might we parse the data differently in order to make sure that we are retaining and recruiting the highest quality licensed teachers in our school divisions and that we have some sense of who are these school divisions who have vacancies where the positions build what is the diversity of this population and so our data and research team as well as patty pitts in licensure are looking to

[02:26:54] provide additional training and support to our school divisions in making sure that those data fields are clearly defined and that we can collect that information which in turn will be used by Dr. Atkins and her staff and by Ms. Pitts as they look at how do we help support school divisions and recruiting and retaining the best qualified staff as well as a diverse staff for all of our children. The next one talks about the current code around the advisory board on teacher education and

[02:27:27] licensure. And this was a recommendation that the board advise that the code be changed relative to the ABTEL committee. And what we found is that in reviewing the code, the code is broad enough right now that it does give the board the opportunity to ask ABTEL to provide policies regarding recruitment and retention of licensed teachers and other licensed staff. So the code already gives that provision in place so he feels very confident that that particular recommendation

[02:28:02] coming out of the jlark report has been met already and then finally uh the general assembly had the jlark report had two policy options for the general assembly to consider around the actual membership of the board of education and those were key to making sure that the board membership was a broad representation of the constituents regionally in Virginia, as well as having some particular expertise in the areas of local government, career and technical education, as well as early childhood. And I'm happy to report that the current membership of the board

[02:28:39] meets both of these policy options. And so I think that these are important because you as a group do represent all Virginians and it is positive that it didn't require General Assembly action for us to

have a board that is very diverse in representing the regions of Virginia as well as a variety of areas that are important to the Department of Ed's work and to the board's work.

[02:29:07] Much like this morning you've heard information around career and technical education as well as early childhood so i think it really goes to support this idea that the board memberships having a diverse set of background is really important to meeting the needs of all virginians and so at this time i'd like to turn the presentation over to dr hollands so that she can begin to present on the other two jlark reports dr hollands thank you so much dr revia good afternoon president gecker dr wilson board members and dr lane my name is Dr. Samantha Hollins, and I'm the Assistant Superintendent for Special Education and Student

[02:29:47] Services here at the department. Linda has teed me up so nicely, so I'm just going to jump into the first study. If you're following our timeline, right on the heels of the agency study, the report from the Joint Legislative Audit Review Commission on a review of the Office of Children's Services, and particularly the provisions of that office on supporting students based out of private day special education schools was released unlike our counterpart agency studies csa and ocs have been a huge focus of work by both the general assembly and jlark many of you if you have an interest in this area or serving in local school divisions probably remember a cost analysis

[02:30:23] survey and study that was done and so this really was a natural iteration of some of that work we've seen over the last couple of years with a particular focus on student studying students served in more restrictive placements. This report contained a total of 18 recommendations, nine of which had the ability to impact the Virginia Department of Education and four of those were directly impacted by General Assembly legislation or Appropriation Act language in the previous session. And so obviously definitely increasing the work of the department to do as a result of what was studied within this particular JLARC study. As we look at the

[02:31:00] findings we really saw some pretty big trends around spending and what has been driving increase of spending around these services and really the nature of students and supports that are provided as you can imagine students with intensive support needs particularly around behavior and support that may look a little bit different than what some of our local school divisions are resourced to provide was really a large focus of this study and so some of the next steps you'll see detailed on the following slide really speak to the role in the department in moving this work forward and so there are three main areas in which we'll see our continued partnership with

[02:31:36] the office of children's services as well as students that are supported by the csa act and in our next slide you can see that that entails guidance and communication to the field regarding these changes in regulations and policies and procedures that are implemented we also will continue what we feel is a very successful collaboration with the office of the secretary of Health and Human Services as well as the Office of Children's Services. The department will not only participate in a work group around these items but also work to outreach the stakeholders involved in local decision making throughout the Commonwealth in order to move this work forward.

[02:32:12] And obviously we will continue internally to study the needs and the impact on the department and work with Dr. Lane as well as leadership here to inform any additional resources or support that are necessary based on work that comes out of this work group so with that i'm going to transition to the last study from jlark that happened this last calendar year and that of course is the review of k-12 special

education in virginia this study was published in december and so is a little bit of early christmas present to it here at the department within this report we have 27 total recommendations um i am happy to report that due to the very hard work of staff within the department

[02:32:49] of special education student services all but five of those recommendations either completed or in progress so you can imagine that this has been a flurry of work but it's really coincided nicely with some of the innovations and improvements we're looking to make within state level leadership and monitoring of local school divisions unlike some of the predecessors with the agency study and csa it has been quite a number of years since jlark study quite frankly any component related to special education much less a focus on on core services that are provided and you'll notice that the study title is about a review of k-12 education it really did focus on

[02:33:27] the relationship of the virginia department of education and our connection with local school divisions so you'll see here a lot of it focused on the provision of support and services as well as the role of doen monitoring this also coincided nicely with some work we've been doing with our federal partners particularly from the office of special education programs and they performed a monitoring visit for Virginia which happens pretty periodically but is based on a number of factors and quite frankly ours was based on the number of years that had been since our federal partners have worked with us on something that's really targeted around monitoring and that happened in

[02:34:02] May of 2019. As we transition to the next slide you'll see that the study really focused on a number of areas that are very important for our provision of services to local school divisions as well as for students many of the recommendations identify the department which obviously creates an impact on both our fiscal and human resources of the agency but we also see a huge opportunity to implement the recommendations and impact on our local school divisions and so you'll see some of these larger buckets if you will really focus on some of the work that we've already identified through the agency study as well as some of the continuing innovations and improvements we've made

[02:34:39] under dr lane's leadership and finally i just want to leave you with a couple of bullet points on how this is directly impacting our students because that's the most important work for us here at the department and we have truly put a priority on those recommendations that impact students and their family directly working on getting parent-friendly resources out with a focus on transition services with a focus on appropriate diploma options and creating creating really collaborative but also jointly effective educational opportunities working with a variety of our partners across the state whether it's our national parent teacher information resource

[02:35:16] center PT and through a number of special education focused advocacy organizations that come to the table with me directly throughout the year to really talk about their concerns and how we can partner together to make sure families students parents and communities have what they need to support our students with disabilities and making sure they're successful not only academically but far beyond the time that they take to walk across the stage so with that i will pause and i know i speak for dr revio when i say thank you for your time and we're more than happy to answer any questions related to any of the three j-lock reports we just reviewed

[02:35:51] well thank you uh are there any questions from board members dr wilson thank you um thanks to you both for the presentation and I don't necessarily have a question but just an observation that the recommendations and the actions that the department is taking particularly around the third report

Dr. Hollins that you reviewed well two observations generally across all three of the reports that you all have highlighted to some degree I think I wonder if there's a an opportunity

[02:36:27] for us to communicate more fully proactively about what is happening at the department to the broader public because sometimes there's a misperception because people just don't know what the department is doing in each of these areas or how the department is improving and all of those kinds of things maybe we are victims of not wanting to toot you know the horn too loudly but i think there may be an opportunity the second is particularly around the third report on special education um and its connection to the overall work of the board around equity around teacher

[02:37:01] quality around you know so you know tying the response to the jlark report the department's response to the jlark report to the overall work of the board in the area of equity teacher quality principal preparation and support all of those things just ensuring that we have that we are very clearly aligning all of the i know that we are but it gets back to communication you know how are we helping people understand that the work in response to the jlark report is not isolated work but rather it's a part of the larger whole and ensuring that we are drawing those connections

[02:37:38] consistently as we talk about the work across the board so an observation uh question uh not necessarily for discussion though you're welcome to respond only bringing it up here as an item for consideration thank you thank you dr wilson i think those are those are all wonderful points i will say that it's it's been great to have the support obviously with dr reby and her work but i would speak personally that dr lane and mr fairheart have ensured that the work across these three reports has been part of our continued meeting process at a video leadership level and most importantly really to even go as far as restructuring some of the positions within the

[02:38:16] department so that ability to collaborate around some of our key priorities that you mentioned around teacher recruitment retention and quality development as well as equity is really at the forefront of our conversation whenever we meet and so i really appreciated that support and i think also you know keep in mind this is year two for me right but since coming on board it's really been wonderful to take the information the work happening here at the department and not only make a concerted effort to make sure that our local school divisions are aware of that but to take time to directly speak to parents and families and I just want to give a huge shout out to

[02:38:53] my office of facilities and family engagement which has created those opportunities for me whether it's next week at our connect for success workshop for parents whether it's through our continued educational opportunities and working with our parent education advocacy and training center or like I stated meeting with folks who are heading up advocacy organizations everybody from the autism society of america central virginia chapter to um you know advocacy rights our three developmental disabilities agencies in the state i think that has been a really welcome not only opportunity for networking but i think those organizations truly feel that we are

[02:39:29] available and want to hear feedback and most importantly make ourselves available and being able to provide direct updates and and hear feedback on those updates from a variety of community so i really appreciate those remarks and we'll continue to keep that among the forefront of our planning yeah anybody else miss halton thank you i appreciate those presentations first one thing i just want to highlight for the public that i was very pleased to see in the jlark report

[02:40:04] that part of what jlark did was survey the school divisions on the services they received the support they received from VDOE and that those results that survey was overwhelmingly positive that there were 90 plus percent on each of the questions they asked that VDOE staff are professional and respectful satisfied with the division's relationship with VDOE staff provide accurate information etc that would not have been the case some years ago and I think that recommends

[02:40:38] reflects some real real significant um uh effort uh from the department to be very service oriented and support oriented to the divisions and i'm just i applaud the hard work that's gone into getting to those those outcomes where the where the divisions now really see the department as a partner um i do have some questions about the school improvement piece that i'll save for when for the next presentation but uh beyond that one of the big picture recommendations i heard coming through uh was uh in in two of the reports the special ed one and the general one was about what

[02:41:18] more can the department do to help attract and retain teachers uh uh high quality teachers and i i would love to hear maybe i missed it but i would love to hear more about what we're doing beyond data collection is an important piece but um you know some of the recommendations are regarding uh additional that might well require additional staffing and it it's a little bit frustrating to have jlark tell us we need to work harder to attract and retain teachers because we've been telling the general assembly that and some of it depends on money um and that just

[02:41:53] hasn't yet been there however what more could we do with existing resources to more aggressively address these issues both within special ed and more broadly are there things we can do about strengthening our education preparation programs are there things we can do in a targeted way to work with divisions that are particularly challenged around protecting and retaining teachers and generally and special ed teachers specifically and and even is there more that

[02:42:28] you know are there ways we can expand our capacity to address these issues and uh this may be for dr lane but i'm curious i mean some there were a number of recommendations from jlark which we appreciate that the general assembly needs to fund more positions but unless and until that happens is there cares act money uh or other federal relief money that can be used to jump start these efforts well secretary holton thank you so much for that feedback and i know that dr revie and perhaps dr lane will weigh in but just briefly i will tell you of course you know whenever we look at studies around areas of need for teachers we always see special

[02:43:07] education listed that's a that's always on the list and it's usually pretty high on the list and so this has always been a huge piece of the work that we here at the department have done whether it's been identifying federal state set-aside funds to use directly towards helping to prop up and support higher education programs to help engage with teacher preparation candidates and and make sure that they're highly qualified and really receive the kind of support that they need within that system before they even enter into a classroom. But we've also not just been, you know, I think comfortable to sit on those laurels, right? We continue to partner with our federal partners around attract, retain, and recruit, which has really been a huge impact. You know, this is not

[02:43:47] just a Virginia problem, it's a national problem. And so we continue to kind of seek out some innovative approaches to that. We've been one of the only states that has conducted actual research in this field and we've worked through our journey into teaching academy to really target a couple of school divisions that struggle mightily with having special ed teachers not only identified and serving in positions

as opposed to long-term substitutes but to keep those teachers for a number of years and to make sure they're fully licensed and I can say that the progress we've seen in that program through regions one and eight as well as with Petersburg city public schools this year have been incredible and so we're looking to build

[02:44:23] on that effective research and see how we can grow that model as well as a seek outside additional funding you know the department of special education student services has received two major grants over the last two years from the u.s department of education focused on recruitment and retention of specialized instructional support staff and we are not done yet we are always out there looking for resources and opportunity to be among the best and brightest and thinking innovatively about the programs that we can offer to our local school divisions our higher ed partners and most importantly talk to more people about the the gift that being

[02:45:00] involved in education is and how we can support them and most importantly to dr wilson's point helping to bring a lens of equity so that we're working to support teacher candidates and folks interested in the field that look like the students that they're serving and so to creating those positive relationships and so um i'll step off my soapbox now but we we agree with you this is incredibly important and we are not done seeking ways to continue to resource this and also find a solution that works for Virginia. And I'll just add a little more. I don't think we can completely detach this for the need for additional resources because I don't think that

[02:45:37] the things that are going to really make an impact on teacher recruitment and retention are going to happen shy of some of the investments the board has already been advocating for. So obviously higher teacher pay is would be a number one priority a number two priority would be um fully funding the standards of quality uh but some of the things that we're thinking about and in no way do i intend this to be comprehensive uh miss holton but one of the we're thinking about how we can provide some efficiencies so one of the things that we're exploring or beginning to think about is could we create a statewide teacher application and and points portal to make the

[02:46:17] uh licensure process more efficient to you know reduce the cost on on buying these systems locally but then teacher applications and information could transfer between division to division and when a teacher applies to one division they can apply to 10 or 15 at a time we have a portal like that but it doesn't actually link to the local systems and so we think kind of bringing that technology a little bit more modern will open up more candidate opportunities across the divisions Obviously the number one factor in retention in addition to teacher pay is principal support, and so we've really ramped up a lot of different opportunities in the principal support realm,

[02:46:56] but I think there's more to do there. And I think what you're going to hear in the school improvement report is going to talk about this idea of case management and how we can provide tailored support to school divisions in addition to those schools that just are struggling to meet our accreditation benchmarks um but i i will say and i and um we were hoping that jlark would be more aggressive on recommending your soqs we were also hoping that jlark would be more aggressive on the staffing that we need but you may have seen in their first report that you know that employees at the department are routinely reporting working more than 40

[02:47:35] and sometimes 60 hours a week and that there is a there is a capacity issue and so part of what you're going to see in the next report is how we're going to make some recommendations to increase

capacity, especially in this very localized technical assistance that we think will help in these factors. Jaylor made a number of recommendations around teacher mentoring, not your SOQ, but mentoring applications and mentoring processes. We've already started the process to update some of those. But again, I think the big impact comes with the the resources that the board has been recommending.

[02:48:08] Okay, thank you. Anybody else? If not, thank you both for the presentation and we will move on to item N. Thank you. Office of School Quality's response to recommendations from the JLARP report.

[02:48:29] Dr. Ortiz and I guess now newly minted Dr. Dreyer, is that what I was given to understand before? Well, Dr. Dreyer tells me that when you defend your dissertation at one of the Virginia universities uh post defense you can be called doctor but he says at harvard harvard however you say it up there uh at harvard uh it is actually uh delayed until the moment of graduation but uh i also want to add my congrats to matt congratulations to you thank you okay all right

[02:49:04] well good afternoon president gecker members of the board and dr lane it's been nearly nine months since i joined the agency and six months since i last presented to this board i'm dr relly ortiz the director of the office of school quality and co-presenting with me this afternoon is the newly minted matt dryer a doctoral resident within our unit on behalf of the tiny but mighty osq team i bring greetings and i'm proud to share just a piece of our work with you during this presentation and so our purpose this afternoon is to provide information that addresses the office of school quality's response to the JLARP recommendations. Thank you to our colleagues, Dr. Rivia and Dr.

[02:49:43] Hollins, for providing some of the context during the previous presentation. Our presentation will provide some additional context, analysis, and possible next steps. Our charge was to recommend a new school improvement model for use throughout the Commonwealth, one that focuses on coordinating and providing personalized quality support to our divisions and schools. The proposed plan is a multi-year plan that allows our team to develop and implement a comprehensive school improvement model for all schools to work with currently identified schools with level two and level three school quality indicators and to identify and provide intense support for schools on the

[02:50:20] cusp of being identified it is our goal as schools are identified that the office of school quality will provide targeted support in order to make timely adjustments to impact student learning the office of school quality is responsible for monitoring state and federally identified schools schools identified with a level 2 school quality indicator and academic achievement or level 3 in any of the school quality indicators and divisions with a memorandum of understanding require and receive osq support during the 1920 school year more than 250 of the state's 1825 public schools

[02:50:59] were identified for monitoring due to the impacts of covid and wave accreditation for the current year and next year we are operating with 1920 data. The OSQ's current personnel authorization is 12 staff members including myself, the associate director or admin assistant, and a mix of federal and state school improvement coordinators and specialists. The current ratio of one OSQ team member to 22 schools requiring assistance has severely limited the VDOE's ability to move far beyond from a compliance-focused approach to a school improvement model that utilizes a coaching

[02:51:34] approach that supports co-constructing sustainable capacity at the school and division level. As noted from the JLARC report, many of the OSQ processes were compliance driven with little personalization or coaching. Based on feedback from the field, school leaders did not agree that our office

helped to build capacity or sustainable improvements. And survey respondents also shared that there was little trust between OSQ and the divisions in schools we supported.

[02:52:01] And just as we say with our students, we can't reach them if we can't teach them. so in our transformation over the past year we embedded frequent opportunities to work side by side and co-construct the personalized model of support while also maintaining the fidelity in the compliance piece of our work so the j-log report provides three recommendations regarding school quality today's presentation addresses recommendation aid the general assembly and its budget language directed to the department to develop and implement a plan to be presented to the chairs of the house education and appropriations committee and senate education and health and

[02:52:41] finance and appropriations committees no later than november 1st 2021. so in our current structure and areas of responsibility we have provided here some additional context regarding the office's work as noted in the top right of your screen the compliance piece remains our primary charge but how we approach that work has truly morphed based on dr lane's vision the support of the agency, feedback from our stakeholders and also the most recent revisions to the SOAs.

[02:53:12] A large percentage of our resources are still used in supportive divisions with a memorandum of understanding and identified level 2 and level 3 schools. In this year alone, our office conducted phase 1 and phase 2 of state and federal monitoring for approximately 300 schools.

[02:53:29] If you note, that's the last bullet under OSQ compliance. In this process, we not only satisfied the compliance portion of state and federal requirements, but we also took advantage of the time to provide feedback on the school improvement process utilizing the coaching approach which nearly all of the division leaders and school principals commended and shared an appreciation for the new process and from the initial report where trust was a huge barrier until now we have built some strong bridges throughout the state by offering that meaningful support and coaching and during this year have received technical assistance requests from nearly 60 divisions

[02:54:04] including nottaway danville norfolk buckingham greensville and portsmouth just to name a few after the monitoring meetings those same team members followed up with a written report of recommendations to the schools this second round which our team is currently in the midst of will allow us to dig deeper into school's essential actions and continue to model effective monitoring strategies and probing questions to support instructional leadership in our schools so with all the necessary and impactful work taking place there are still opportunities to expand support in areas such as targeted professional learning facilitating professional learning networks or

[02:54:40] divisions in schools with like needs and offering true and consistent collaboration in support of student achievement. Just last week our office held a principal leader conference in support of current principals and also to provide support to the assistant principal pipeline. We had nearly 400 participants over the two days and based on survey data over 95 percent of participants reported that the sessions were beneficial or extremely beneficial. So we know there's a need for collaboration and professional learning among our educators and as leaders of school quality within the commonwealth we are obligated to support those needs and as you can see by the sheer number of staff in this organizational structure there are some foundational restraints

[02:55:19] that limit this team's ability and so while we are doing the work to advance video ease efforts to provide support and resources to meet school divisions continuous improvement needs as noted in red

the video is not optimally organized nor is the office of school quality adequately resourced to support the current nearly 300 schools in our care with a school rating of level two or three, provide intense supports for our divisions with a memorandum understanding and their leadership teams, and truly advance the work of school quality and continuous improvement throughout

[02:55:55] the commonwealth. Under our authorizing environment of ESSA and SOAs, we retain the primary charge of providing technical assistance to ensure all schools are improving and moving towards full accreditation. So in addition to providing context and some additional data points, we also want to highlight that our approach is in line with this board's priority to ensure the successful implementation of the profile of a Virginia graduate and the accountability system for school quality and the agency's goal to ensure student success and high school quality.

[02:56:30] In yesterday's board meeting, Dr. Gorham from Virginia Beach, Dr. Gaia from Goochland and Dr. McCullough from BASCD and a few others discuss micro credentials and how that work supports the need for a personalized approach to professional learning. In that same vein, our approach must be personalized and in addition to the personalization aspect, another layer requires a trusting and collaborative partnership with school and division leadership. Our office and the agency accepts and embraces our charge to advance divisions and schools resources and efforts to ensure a culture of continuous improvement and truly this is a highly personalized approach and systematic process

[02:57:10] and currently our office is not adequately staffed to do this work in depth in regards to a future ask for funding we developed a plan for the transition to a new school improvement model with an estimate of additional staffing for a model that will strengthen and differentiate our work with schools and divisions i'll pass it to matt now to share some additional research and some recommendations for next step thank you dr ortiz after reviewing the research surrounding state education agencies role in school improvement we found that states uniquely positioned at the intersection of federal local and external stakeholders can

[02:57:46] serve as coordinators of capacity building efforts throughout the statewide system of supports systemic capacity for change is achieved by the state creating and disseminating knowledge enhancing the supply of personnel equipped for school improvement and providing the necessary data systems to support school improvement but to do so they must be able to move beyond the rules-based technical assistance and reach far more deeply into the operation of schools as well as draw upon the talent and expertise outside of the SEA's traditional compliance roles. However, reaching deeply into the inner workings of Virginia's 132 different school

[02:58:25] divisions absent understanding the contextual factors impacting their performance may lead to imposing solutions absent a clear understanding of the problem or worse layering on solutions that fail to address root causes. Schools and districts are complex adaptive systems where parts of the system change as they interact with one another. Therefore, any interventions must take a systems approach to problem identification or risk treating the symptom, not the root cause of the problem.

[02:58:56] Moreover, state education agencies attempting to improve school performance through technical assistance should do so in ways that not only address these complexities through tailored support but also capture the lessons learned from each intervention to increase the agency's organizational capacity and adaptability. Looking across the country at what other improvement models states are employing, we found several states, Ohio, Georgia, and North Carolina, introducing regional

case management systems. We will continue to monitor and dialogue with these states to capitalize on their lessons learned and help inform

[02:59:33] the OSQ's transformation. Our approach focuses on two levels: aligning the department's internal processes and adding capacity. The technical and adaptive nature of school quality work demands a coherent whole of DOE strategy which cannot be achieved through siloed or ad hoc tactics.

[02:59:56] An emerging example of the interdepartmental collaboration approach to school improvement occurs right now during the corrective action plan review meetings with our MOU divisions. During these monitoring meetings, department representatives from special education, VTSS, Elementary and Secondary Education, and the Office of School Quality execute their monitoring and oversight responsibilities with division leadership, which leads to a more unified, coherent experience for the division.

[03:00:24] This concept isn't new. Indeed, the DOE Strategic Plan identifies the need to collaborate across the DOE departments and offices to develop a database continuous school and child care improvement planning process encompassing the school and child care quality indicators to build local leadership capacity. The missing element then is to actualize this by adopting and embracing a unified approach with not just accountability, but shared responsibility for school quality throughout the Commonwealth. In addition to department representation, we believe that to truly meet

[03:01:00] the needs of schools and divisions, we need their voice in the conversation and we'll include them in advisory roles to the committee. Our second recommendation involves building on the department's regional superintendent model and the Office of School Quality's emerging regional liaisons. In this model, the Office of School Quality maintains compliance and statewide coordination responsibilities in collaboration with the Department's School Quality Committee.

[03:01:28] Regional support teams will collaborate with divisions, schools, educators, families, and regional partners through a continuous improvement process to ensure each child in Virginia has access to a high-quality education. These regional support teams provide professional learning opportunities and needs-based coaching focused on building leadership capacity, team development and inclusive instructional practices to assist schools in improving educational outcomes. This model gives the department the capacity to differentiate support by need and leverage the power of deep collaboration to identify and address root causes inhibiting

[03:02:07] high-quality instruction. Here you see the representative capabilities resident in each regional support team. While these capabilities represent most of the functional areas division and school leaders must provide, they must also integrate them together in a coherent manner.

[03:02:24] We envision the preponderance of the team's efforts going to the schools and divisions that need it most, those with an MOU, Level 3, and Level 2 indicators. We also see the office identifying schools for targeted support based more on identified need, excuse me, versus demand, and providing high-quality universal support to all schools and divisions throughout the Commonwealth by leveraging the department's position within the education sector to convene stakeholders together in communities of practice.

[03:02:57] The regional support team lead will help identify opportunities for growth and take a systemic approach to build the capacity of division and school leadership to address these issues. Key to the success

of this model is the increased use of data to drive decision making.

[03:03:13] Our goal is to not only use reflective data to engage schools and divisions that are in identified status, but to identify those that are at risk of moving toward identified status. And understanding that scaling from our current 12-person office to a full-blown regional support team model is a process and quite an undertaking, we also recommend adding an interim capacity in the near term to set the conditions for future success.

[03:03:41] By adding five full-time employees, we'll be able to expand our support capacity to increase support to MOU, Level 3 and Level 2 schools, going from two visits a year to three visits a year, followed up with monthly check-ins, increased use of data-informed decision-making.

[03:04:05] We'll also be able to use data and lead leading the school quality committee and broaden our technical assistance offerings based on need. Here you can see the phased approach with increased office school quality personnel capacity.

[03:04:23] Of note, you will see that the OSQ staff to schools in need of support ratio is currently 1 to 22. With the interim capacity of one data analytics specialist and an additional four school improvement specialists, we reduced that ratio for one OSQ member to 13 identified schools.

[03:04:43] And then in the full OSQ capacity, we see adding another data specialist and 10 people per regional support team, which would give us a ratio of one OSQ member to four school, four identified schools.

[03:05:03] As we build the department's capacity, we increase our scope and scale, moving from compliance to coaching in the interim, followed by case management and capacity building in a regional structure. We see the estimated cost of the interim capacity beginning in FY23, followed by the projected costs going forward from FY24.

[03:05:28] Adopting both recommendations requires changes to the department's resources, processes, and priorities. This is a multi-year endeavor that, to be implemented with fidelity, will require the department to identify and install the necessary competency, leadership, and organizational drivers.

[03:05:45] We're excited to develop the plan over the upcoming months and continue the office's transformation. I'll turn it back over to Dr. Ortiz to bring us home. Thank you, Matt. In our office, we repeatedly say that without data, we fall back on what we want to believe.

[03:06:03] This data demonstrates that even with the will and skill, OSQ does not have the number of staff to effectively create and sustain a model of continuous school improvement throughout our 132 school divisions, and more specifically with the 267 identified schools that are currently in our care.

[03:06:20] In order to personalize support and resources, we need a staffing model that supports the different needs of our divisions and division leadership capacity. We need a model that supports the work of the principals, that supports the work of the teachers, that ultimately positively impacts student outcomes. So with the target of meeting schools where they are and building from that point to ensure all students receive the high quality education they deserve, our team needs the human capital to work collaboratively, efficiently, and effectively to improve identified schools, those that are on the cusp of being identified and also to provide a foundation of continuous school improvement for all schools throughout Virginia, because we know there is always

[03:06:57] room for growth and improvement. The expanded regional support model will be a huge step toward actualizing that goal. The regional support teams will utilize a systematic approach using the drivers that research Dr. Lane and the team have illustrated as two levers in improving student outcomes. And those include the implementation of an aligned and culturally relevant curriculum, the provisions of common assessments that are aligned, the analysis of student achievement data to identify the needs, the implementation of tailored, timely, tiered, evidence-based interventions, the implementation of effective professional learning communities,

[03:07:32] the utilization of technology to support, track, and monitor data systems, and effective utilization of the teacher evaluation system that facilitate solid partnerships between human resources and principals so as we're preparing to wrap up the presentation portion i want to highlight the strength of this model which are in building capacity among our superintendents division leadership and principals and strengthening instructional leadership as referenced earlier with the principal leader conference the leaders across virginia are hungry for collaboration and thought partners as they construct support within their own schools and divisions this model

[03:08:09] is also inclusive of other areas of focus as noted here on the slides related to data utilization supporting an aligned curriculum and aligning resources processes and priorities as board member holton commented during the previous presentation we truly want to be partners in this work and so the jlog report did put a spotlight on areas that bdoe and osq had the foresight to identify as areas of improvement which boil down to the fact that in order to truly assess the unique challenges affecting student performance and to personalize support and resources we need a staffing model that supports that work so i'm building a better

[03:08:45] way forward. Internally, Dr. Lane has supported the establishment of the school quality committee, which Matt mentioned earlier, and externally, we plan to ask for additional funding to support an expanded school quality organization model. Thank you all for leaning in during our presentation. At this time, we will respond to any questions you all may have or open the floor for comments.

[03:09:04] Okay. Are there any questions? And thank you both for the presentation. Thank you. All right. I guess first Dr. Duran, then Dr. Wilson, then Ms. Holton, if that's okay.

[03:09:21] thank you mr gecker just no major questions but i just want to say dr ortiz thank you for the good overview presentation and and i really appreciated you and mr or dr dreyer putting together the the real need for what the resources are oftentimes and i've said it you know various yesterday i was talking about early childhood we have a lot of great ideas and plans but really understanding what that's going to mean to implement those and to really do them well and to support and be that support that i heard you talking about dr ortiz and your whole focus throughout i was very clear to me that in your role as director of school quality you see your charges to support our

[03:09:59] schools and divisions and being able to effectively do that i'm really glad you were able to articulate what that looks like and what's needed so i hope that we'll get be able to continue how we support that whether it's us at the state board what we can do the general assembly etc dr lane i know we'll find ways to make sure we can really walk the talk of what we're saying we want to do because oftentimes it's the inability to do that that then causes some of the inequities we see that causes some of the school divisions not getting the direct supports that they should be getting and it's not simply because there's not a desire but as you laid out so clearly in these last few slides

[03:10:38] in these recommendations the two of you it's really a need that our central video we needs to have put in place in order to make that happen so i just want to thank you for kind of crystallizing that i think it's stuff we kind of knew already but for the public and everyone to see and understand how important that's going to be to match what the research and our best practices tell us needs to be happening and then our ability to actually deliver that so i just want to commend you for that it really gave me a good visual uh i had thought about it before but i was really able to visualize it visualize in a different way appreciate it thank you dr wilson thank you

[03:11:17] dr ortiz thank you so much mr dreyer thank you very much for the presentation um i appreciate the shift in the culture this cultural shift that you're you're seeking with the office of school quality that's very clear and i like the idea of this support coaching thank you for pointing us toward other states that are doing similar work particularly North Carolina but I do have one question just for clarity so it's it I think what I hear you saying and as I read the presentation

[03:11:50] the goal is to have a model of coaching and support while also holding divisions accountable so in the model that you line out for FY23 and then subsequently in 24 or 25 of that of the members of that team that you identify who would actually kind of be the lead in i understand there's a team working with each division but among the list of positions kind of where does the responsibility

[03:12:24] for the coach rest does that makes does that question make sense and so dr wilson i i think i understand the question if i don't let let's go back to it in my response sure the the primary responsibility but still live within the office of school quality and so our arm would be extended with the regional support teams and so the accountability is still to to us to move the lever with student outcomes but really taking that team approach to personalize and what do they need how are we utilizing the data analyzing the data to determine what they need and really

[03:13:01] co-constructing that with the division and so is it the specialists that you have listed there is that would that be their primary role to kind of be the point person within or to each of the divisions and then the other uh roles the other functions then come on as support finance HR all of the okay thank you that clarifies yeah great thank you I I the the model is really intriguing thank you um Ms. Holkin so my first question uh thank you uh for the for the great work my first

[03:13:34] question is to timing so i see you saying uh recommending that we take the interim staffing up the staffing up to your recommended interim level which means adding five people still to a frankly woefully inadequate level as from what we're hearing from you based on what's going on in other states but that we're talking about doing that in the fiscal year 23 and we're now in fiscal 21 so we're talking about 15 months before we even begin this ramp up and that really worries me is

[03:14:11] there any way we can accelerate the ramp up again using we've got all these federal funds now coming you all's way and that this should be at the heart of what what those federal funds are about how are we addressing equity um how are we address addressing our our media schools and if we can't ramp it up is there any way we can more target your resources so i'm very worried you know are we we asked this question when we put the current soa approach into effect we put we put the question to your your predecessor can you manage this this number of schools

[03:14:49] and you know the thought was yes but now i'm looking at the numbers in virginia compared to other states we're just asking you to target too many schools for the resources you've got and is there a way we can cut our losses frankly even if we've told you to target 260 schools can you is there a way we can give

you permission to uh choose to have a very very light touch for 150 of those 260 so you can really work with the 100 left or whatever the right mix is or or does it

[03:15:25] make sense to continue to do 260 schools even if you can't do it well i will uh i'll answer the finance questions uh miss holton thank you for those and uh there were so many questions there i will try to make sure i get them all sorry about that the um so the general assembly has already adopted their fy 22 budget so that's why the program is targeted for fy 23. your question about using federal funds is certainly a possibility uh and i apologize and ask that in your answer that in your last question the general assembly did pass language that requires them to have

[03:16:00] oversight of the state set aside. And so whereas we have this money, we must go back to them to spend any of it. And so there is belief that there will be a special session of some kind to address these federal funds at some time in the summer, fall, or hopefully not that late. But certainly we will consider that in our proposal to them. We're always really reticent at the department to fund positions that are ongoing beyond the term of the three years, unless we have some certainty that the General Assembly is going to fund them in perpetuity. The General Assembly

[03:16:39] already put some things that we recommended in perpetuity into CARES Act funding. We're already facing some fears of being able to maintain some of those projects. So the answer is yes, those funds can be used. We will consider that in our proposal, but the FY23 budget will be our next opportunity for permanent and ongoing funding. So that was that question. Then your other question was around can you relieve us of the requirement to work with schools and the such.

[03:17:09] We are already tailoring assistance, frankly. We're funded at a compliance level, right? That's very clear. And when our predecessors answered whether they had the capacity to do this, we have the capacity to do basic compliance requirements. And to be honest there, what we look at is if you've only got, I'm going to use a metaphor, this isn't an exact school, but if you've only got a one level two, and maybe it's just in chronic absenteeism, you get a vastly different level of support even today than if you have a number of level threes or on the brink of being an MOU

[03:17:43] type to school division. And so I would not at this time recommend changing your SOA to reduce the focus because i think we're focusing on much better things that we did in the past but i would continue to encourage us to tailor supports to the needs of schools and the regional support team will be able to allow us to do that even better than we can do today and um just following on dr wilson's question a second there is the regional support team leads in that model and so those regional there's the specialist in the office who will you know be responsible for the accountability but the regional support team leads will be responsible for the technical

[03:18:21] assistance in those regions and and i just wanted to clarify that piece and uh and keep in mind that we have uh we have we are also going to build as part of this in time and we only alluded to this because it's not recommended jlark a process and this is what north carolina did where even if you're not a school in improvement you can submit a case request to us for support from the regional support team so that we can help schools uh they mentioned that it was on the cusp of needing improvement maybe if you're not even on the cusp of needing improvement but you really need work in the equity space in the hr space we want the regional support team to be able to work with

[03:18:59] anyone and that we really do focus on school quality not just those that need school improvement thank you thank you anybody else don't see anybody so uh dr ortiz and almost dr dreyer uh

thank you so much for the informative presentation uh i will say that you know i've had the opportunity over the last year to you know sit in on some of the mou meetings with dr ortiz and it is fairly clear

[03:19:36] uh from the tone of those meetings that uh the office is doing a great job i mean uniformly respected and the comments coming back from the local jurisdictions are always good and thankful so i appreciate the board appreciates all that you're doing uh in that regard thank you so much we appreciate it thanks y'all thank you okay all right and move on to item o uh status report on covet 19 impacts on pre-k to 12 education in virginia uh assistant superintendent coy and

[03:20:13] bowling is that right that's correct perfect well good afternoon everybody is a pleasure to be back with you this afternoon uh i know we have the distinct honor of being last over the course of three days, so we will do our best to give you what's relevant here. Happy to answer questions along the way, but won't belabor this too long. So our presentation today is intended to just provide some general COVID updates to ensure that you have the latest information about what's

[03:20:47] happening in Virginia with our public schools and COVID policy and programs. And then my Partnering in crime here Michael Bolling will provide an update on the second periodic report.

[03:21:02] You will remember that the periodic reports have been required of all divisions as a condition for the 180 180 days 990 hour waiver and so we have the results from the second. This follows on the tails of the report we brought to you in January with the first report out. We do anticipate just by way of setting the landscape a third and final periodic report from our divisions at the conclusion of the school year so with that it is my job today to just provide very high level updates for you

[03:21:39] all as it relates to covet activities in the commonwealth and on the next slide you'll see just a couple of bullets i am more than happy to spend uh time talking about any any one of these items in greater detail and providing additional context but i'm going to fly through these with you today. First, since you last received an update from the department in January, the CDC and VDH and DOE have issued updated guidance. This is the now well-known change from six feet to three feet in school settings if it facilitates bringing students back to the

[03:22:15] classroom. Virginia had already permitted three feet of distance in our classrooms. We were a bit ahead of the CDC there, though they caught up and we all got aligned in the end. Additionally, i just wanted to make you all aware of two pieces of legislation that came out of the 2021 session that are related to covet in some way shape or form so the first one is senate bill 1303 uh you you have likely heard about this one that requires in-person instruction be offered to any

[03:22:50] enrolled student by the division in the 21-22 school year there are some some specific health circumstances in which divisions can close when there are extreme outbreaks and they receive such guidance from their local public health department. However, the baseline of this and the bottom line for students, families, and divisions alike is that 180 days, 990 hours have to be offered in person to those students who want it. Divisions may offer virtual programs on top of that requirement

[03:23:25] and students and families may choose to opt in. Additionally, the General Assembly passed legislation related to new growth assessments, and this legislation will be phased in over the next few years. However, the immediate implications to make you all aware of are that in grades three through eight, math and reading, the bill requires that we assess students at the beginning of the 21-22 school year so we will be deploying our computer adaptive tests based on sol content in the fall

[03:24:02] we're working through all of the details of that now but this will be new and those assessments will be deployed in the fall that will give us a more nuanced way of assessing where our students are academically and what type of unfinished learning they may need to have addressed throughout the school year and so just like our sol tests both parents and teachers will get the data from those assessments very quickly after they are deployed in the fall uh the other items here

[03:24:38] well the next two i should say are pretty health specific um the first is a covet screening and diagnostic diagnostic testing program in virginia schools that is actually being administered largely by the Department of Health, but we are our co-administrators there. The idea here from the U.S. Health Department, Health and Human Services Department, is that significant financial resources are being made available to those schools that want to opt into voluntary screening

[03:25:11] programs for students or staff. The resources are coming down the pike. Virginia will receive about 257 million dollars to deploy to this end and the virginia department of health is in the process of fleshing out the details of that program and administering a pilot this spring to start with those divisions that want to again they can opt into this to provide that additional layer of mitigation in our school settings it is not required as part of the cdc guidance for operating

[03:25:45] a school safely in person but is considered to be an additional love layer of protection that some schools in some programs may opt into so it could be all your students it could be your staff it could be those participating in athletics there are lots of different ways for divisions to take advantage of that if they are interested finally a quick update on vaccinations of school staff as you likely knew we had been surveying divisions on a weekly basis to understand how the vaccination efforts were going with school staff. We are pleased to report that all divisions

[03:26:22] have been able to make vaccinations available to their staff. About two-thirds of public school division staff in Virginia have received their first dose. More than half have received both doses of their vaccines. We are continuing to track that, but on a less frequent basis as that vaccination effort plays out across the state. As I mentioned, the periodic report information you'll hear today is part of the instructional waivers. The DOE is now in the

[03:26:56] process of accepting waiver requests from divisions for release from the 180 days, 990 hours in person this year. So any division, any school that was not able to offer all of those instructional hours in person has to go through this process. We've tried to streamline it as much as possible and and they had to participate in the periodic reporting.

[03:27:22] That is a rolling window right now. We have given divisions until May the 26th to submit their application to us. And then last but not least, just wanna make you all aware of the federal release efforts that were discussed in the end of the last conversation as well.

[03:27:40] Since we last updated you, the American Rescue Plan was signed into law in March of 2021, And it brings more than $2 billion to the Commonwealth for COVID related relief programs in our school system. By way of context, just to give you a sense of that scale compared to previous relief packages, the first package that came through in March of 2020 was about $240 million.

[03:28:11] The second package that came through in December of 2020 was about a billion dollars, these are all Virginia specific numbers and then, as I mentioned, this one is more than $2 billion so by far the

most significant. package, the vast majority of those dollars are distributed via the title formulas to directly to our divisions, but there is about $200 million there for the state set aside so.

[03:28:40] That was a lightning round on all things COVID. I'm happy to pause there and answer questions and/or share additional information that may be of interest before turning it over to Michael. - Any questions?

[03:28:56] I don't see any, so I guess it's turned over to Michael. Thank you, Holly. - Sounds good, and thank you, Holly, for kicking it off and turning it over. I will pick up at this point and talk a little bit about the data that we received from school divisions regarding instructional delivery and student outcomes.

[03:29:17] This is in comparison to the first periodic data report that we issued in or requested in November. And this latest was collected in early March.

[03:29:33] We did have 132 respondents. And so we had 100% of our divisions reported and we will be able to provide you with a little bit of a detail when it comes to instructional delivery first, and then we'll move into the student outcomes.

[03:29:49] So if you could go on to the next slide, please. So some of the key takeaways here are, and we tried to summarize these rather than going through hundreds of data slides, but some of the key takeaways that are, while 89% of our division said that, reported that they had increases in in-person instructional time, 72.7 percent of divisions are now offering instruction at either to at least some students at four or five days per week and they fall into the categories of partial in-person or in-person

[03:30:27] and we will get to a breakdown of the percentages of each of those and the other categories and in just a few slides in addition all school divisions will be offering some in-person learning to students by april 26 and so we are very close to that mark now additionally percentages of students choosing to work fully remotely increases as they get older and we'll have a breakdown by elementary middle and high school in just a minute in the following slide that breaks that down just a

[03:31:00] little bit more and finally 41.6 percent of school divisions report an increase in synchronous learning time which i know was a particular area of interest for the board on slide seven you can see that we have changed our definitions just slightly we have added a category called predominantly remote that where learning is currently remote for 90 at least 95 of us of their students and in person for all others in addition while each if you look at these

[03:31:39] categories in person and hybrid and then fully remote are very self-explanatory the partial in person and partial hybrid are basically saying that there's a mix depending on the grade levels of either hybrid or fully or in-person education so Emily if we can move to slide eight here's a comparison of instructional modalities by division percentages of divisions in each category so we We started with September 8th with over 50% of our divisions representing well over 80%

[03:32:18] of our -- or close to 80% of our student body in the fully remote category. We're now down to 1.5%. That's two divisions that are either falling in that predominantly remote or fully remote. As a reminder, they will be moving into -- at least one of those will be moving into another category as of April 26th.

[03:32:41] see that we've had tremendous increases in the bottom two categories moving to partial in person which is offering four days per week in person for many students or in person that's four or five

days for all if we move to the next there's a breakdown by region by superintendents region so you can see and you know this is hard to just look at these numbers and take away something but as you want to reflect you could go back to this these data and and take a deeper dive into that on slide 10

[03:33:19] we have a box and whisker plot uh for elementary middle and high high and for those of you that it's been a while since you've had a statistics class i just want to remind you how box and whisker plots represent data so first of all the question was what percentage of your students have chosen fully remote instruction at that time which was early in march we had three divisions you see represented at the top three dots they were close to 100 and so some of the divisions that were fully remote

[03:33:54] did respond with a hundred percent as as having their their students choosing fully remote instruction if you look at box and whisker plots what is represented in the box is 50 of the sample data so 50 of the responses fall within the box and the number that's highlighted in the middle of each box or slightly to you know skewed is the median of the entire data set

[03:34:29] and so you see that in elementary school we have a much lower percentage of students choosing fully remote instruction than we do in the high school setting. And I'll pause there for questions. Hearing none, I'll move on. For the academic outcomes, let's move right on to slide 13, Emily. The key

[03:35:08] findings were, as compared with the first periodic report, divisions report more elementary students at or above expected achievement levels, which is really great news. However, in both the middle and the high school most divisions continue to report students are failing two or more classes as compared to the to to the same time last year and then finally when we look at externally provided data it indicates that we're seeing student growth in reading and mathematics over time when you when you compare the growth in reading and mathematics what we're seeing is

[03:35:48] lower growth when we're comparing this uh this year than in past years and so i have some examples of that data and we'll dive into that uh in in just a couple of slides so on slide 13 you'll see the academic outcomes when we talk when we talk in depth about the higher percentage of divisions reporting um that 50 of their students were at or above expectations

[03:36:19] In either elementary three five reading and PK five mathematics. So we're showing that 50% of the divisions are are saying that their kids are doing better in those areas. They're, they're at or above the expected level. And you can see the actual breakdown in the PK and PK 235 in each of the areas of mathematics in reading. Now these are locally determined measures. So they were determining At or above expectations based on local measures, then that means that not all division was divisions were using the same measure.

[03:36:56] To come to determine that percentage and 23 of the divisions reported that they were still in the in the process of assessing students or. Coming up with the results on their percentages, if you move to the next slide this shows the breakdown of two or more students.

[03:37:18] Michael Williams: Two or more students that were failing two or more classes compared to the second at the end of the second grading period. Michael Williams: Compared to last year and you do see increases in those areas, as I stated in the first slide and then in on slide 16 the next slide.

[03:37:36] Michael Williams: here's one of a few examples that the first two slides i'm going to show you are focusing in on reading and what this is is if you'll notice the red bars indicate. the growth, the

percentage growth from fall 19 to winter 20, and then the blue is fall of 20 to winter 21. And so while students are gaining and growing, they're just not gaining and growing at the same rate as last year.

[03:38:10] As we move to the next slide for reading. This is another another indicator of the same that says, so this is great. So each set of bars. If you go left to right. The first to look at grades. grade three the second two at grade four the third two at grade five and what it's comparing is this is another one of our external vendors it's saying how much how much growth were students showing in uh in previous years during the winter to march time frame versus this year and you see

[03:38:46] that the the bars this year there are less of the deep green than the bar to its immediate left if that is hopefully clear. So basically you're looking at the size of the greens in comparing this year to last.

[03:39:08] If you go on to the next slide, the last two slides are the same types of things and we're looking at mathematics now. And so you see that fall 19 to 20, there were some great gains in mathematics. And in 20 to 21, there's still some really tremendous gains.

[03:39:23] However, just not quite as much as we had had in past in as compared to last year and then the final slide has another. Vendors and it goes back to that looking at the comparison of historical data to this year's data in the the size of the green section is smaller in the right portion of each comparison.

[03:39:48] So at this point, I'll wrap it up and I'll take questions or provide any kind of additional information that you may seek. Thank you both. Dr. Wilson.

[03:40:05] Thank you, President Gecker. I just have a clarifying question. Is the data, Michael, that you just went through, is that regardless of instructional modality? So this is across all modalities that the data is showing?

[03:40:23] It is. Because they fluctuate, in many cases, they fluctuate. And so it's hard to, you know, we could have said at the time of, but it didn't have any kind of scale of how long they had been in that modality. So it's tough to dissect that data. Okay, thank you. Anybody else? Dr. Mann?

[03:40:47] Yes, thank you, President Gecker. Thank you, Mr. Bowling. Just really one quick question. because the slides around the outcome data talked about external I just wondered if that was representative of all of the districts or a subset for which you had external data to appreciate sort of how students were progressing. Dr. Mann that is a that's an outstanding question and I probably should have mentioned that when I got to those slides so thank you for bringing it up.

[03:41:17] So we received we did reach out to some of our external vendors that have a pretty large foothold in our school divisions and so these are for large numbers of data and it's typically in situations where they have comparative numbers from one year to the next so that and it is the same assessment that they are reporting on versus our self-reported data which differs in measures by division.

[03:41:45] but how not i'm not being familiar with how many districts are using the external what overall percent would you say represents of the total universe of the school districts right uh the the first bar charts were from nwea map the the blue versus red and i believe that they're in um roughly i believe 70 to 80 percent of our divisions dr lane is that to your i think it's a a little lower a little lower than that yeah or i i my gut was that it was that but i

[03:42:23] think when we did the first periodic report we found it was lower i think you're right yes and i ready is something similar and uh holly did you want to weigh in and i already i should mention i believe is

in fairfax so it represents a very large population okay that's helpful thank you okay any other questions don't see any so thank you both uh very informative i think it's you know very glad that we decided to have these periodic presentations it really is helpful to

[03:42:59] deal with some of the data as opposed to some of the supposition around what's going on in the school so you know i although it may look like nobody's paying attention sometimes as the last presenters of the day i can assure you we are i mean this is very meaningful stuff so thank you both you're welcome okay uh we have a written report and now discussion of current issues uh anybody have any current issues they want to do and dr lane i know you do i just kind of my monthly update on a couple things i i want i put this in the uh notes to you quickly yesterday you

[03:43:37] may have seen it before you logged off but it's it's the month of the military child i'm the chair of the governor's council and i just wanted to encourage you to uh you'd like to show support for our military children um yesterday was the state's purple up day i think my son's school is doing it today so it kind of goes on throughout the month and of course we recognize um uh schools with awards that are especially doing great work in that space i also wanted to mention we've continued to uh well we i i've been continuing towards schools and got many of my staff to come with me but i want to let you know that um uh as of the end of this month we will have visited every

[03:44:15] school division in the commonwealth uh since i came and so i've got two left uh that i've not been to though i went to before i became superintendent i got one that i went to only for a central office meeting i promised him i'd come back uh and actually tour schools and so i look forward to wrapping that up and sharing reflections uh as we move forward but one one reflection that i will share is our school divisions are working really hard to get our students back in person we've seen a lot of school divisions as michael mentioned kind of briefly going from two days to four days and from four days to five days and just the the heroic work

[03:44:50] that to to manage all this i've seen band practice practice outdoors and you know with with gloves on and and when they can i i've seen uh cafeterias renovated into learning spaces i've seen gyms turned into cafeterias it's just it's it's really been amazing and and so um uh just a thank you to all of our school divisions out there for everything that you're doing thank you for that any board members have anything they'd like to say i know it's been a long three days but we can extend another 10 minutes or so.

[03:45:24] Yes, Ms. Halton. - Briefly, Dr. Lane, I know how much you care about band practice. And I just wanna acknowledge that we received a lot of public comment around COVID restrictions for marching band and other performing arts and pointing out what the public commenters understood to be differences in the COVID restrictions for those activities as opposed to athletic activities.

[03:45:51] Can you address that? - Yeah, in the governor's executive order as of April 1st, those activities were identified under underneath social gathering and did not have their own carve out, which severely limited the ability to have some of those projects, especially indoors.

[03:46:11] The governor announced in a press conference earlier this week that he would be updating that. And we got notice of the specifics of that today, but I know that we're gonna put it out publicly tomorrow. And I think our band and performing arts folks will be very pleased.

[03:46:27] I actually think there was a slight executive order made today that's already gone out. And so Holly, do you wanna go into those details? - Yeah, so the governor issued an updated executive order today

to reflect that carve out for performing arts. It is different than the recreational sports carve out, but it does provide opportunity for both indoor and outdoor performances and the parameters around those.

[03:46:55] - Okay, anybody else? don't see anyone uh as i said we've had a pretty good three days of work uh and interestingly enough in three days of work we can actually or three days of discussion we can create about two years worth of work for the board and so it may be a good time to stop meeting now before we create any more uh we're getting to the point where you know the workload uh is you know going to be significant and what i plan to do and actually miss halton suggested this is reach out to a couple board members to take the lead in some of the various areas that are going to be of high focus

[03:47:33] for us and so you know things like uh the continuation of the work plan with regard to evaluation and professional development uh the virtual school regs is another topic and the gifted regs is a third topic so if you all could think about and perhaps get in contact with me you know which of those areas interest you and where you'd be willing to serve as an informal liaison with the department as we move through that process that would be very helpful but that is uh you know my plan uh actually thanks to anne for how we're going to move some of this work forward and have the board engaged early on with the department as opposed to just being presented

[03:48:13] work at the end of the process so i thank her for that suggestion uh and i think that's it unless anybody else has any thing they just need to say other than that uh the hardest working board in and the Commonwealth stands adjourned.

[03:48:28] We'll see you guys in person in June. - Thanks everybody. - Thank you all.



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